

28, Discussions Requiring Supplementation Regarding Certain Historical Problems Following the Failure of China's Feudalization

Personally, I believe that apart from certain minor details, the history of the Chinese empire (中华帝国) over the more than 1,400 years following the Sui (隋) and Tang (唐) dynasties fundamentally requires no further discussion. This is precisely the history of a **restoration-bureaucratic state** (复辟官僚国家) hurtling relentlessly toward a dead end; it is the history of the catastrophes suffered by the Chinese people intensifying progressively.

However, regardless of the circumstances, one invariably discusses the history of one's own nation more extensively than that of other nations, and accessing relevant materials is correspondingly easier. During the year and a half since I returned to Xi'an (西安), numerous issues concerning the Chinese empire subsequent to the bureaucratic restoration have frequently featured in daily discussions between my friends and me.

Regarding these issues of Chinese history that have long confounded domestic and foreign researchers, the unanimous consensus among my friends and me is that the fundamental reason these problems emerged and appear difficult to explain is ultimately caused by the **restoration-bureaucratic system** (复辟官僚制度)—namely, China itself embarked upon an irrevocable, divergent path. The reason scholars are plagued by these problems is that they fundamentally fail to realize that the **restoration of the bureaucratic system** actually occurred in China, and that China failed to undergo **feudalization** (封建化) during the precise historical epoch when it logically ought to have feudalized.

People have been psychologically bluffed by this walking corpse (行尸走肉) of a decrepit empire, which is an exceedingly fascinating phenomenon. It is exactly analogous to the short story *The Emperor's New Clothes* (《皇帝的新装》) authored by the Danish fairy tale writer Hans Christian Andersen: the Sui, Tang, Song (宋), Yuan (元), Ming (明), and Qing (清) dynasties were merely that emperor who believed he was fully clothed yet was utterly naked. However, whether it was the subjects ruled by this emperor or the populace outside this empire, surprisingly, not a single person dared to point out bluntly that this emperor was nothing more than a stark-naked man who wore fundamentally nothing. Even after this foolish emperor had been crushed multiple times by the "barbarians" (蛮夷) he despised, those former victors actually dared not even conceive that the Chinese empire was merely such a pathetic entity. Such a circumstance is truly astonishing; since the dawn of human history, no one has ever heard such a farce.

The **first** frequently discussed issue is whether, following the disintegration of China's unified **classical state** (古典国家) at the end of the Jin Dynasty (晋朝末年), the Southern Dynasties (南朝) regimes exiled in Jiangzuo (江左 / Left of the Yangtze River) could have normally feudalized.

Readers have presumably noticed that when I initially considered the issue of China's **feudalization**, I adopted a perspective prioritizing the North over the South, engaging in minimal discussion regarding the Six Dynasties of Jiangzuo (江左六朝). My rationale for employing this approach is that, from my perspective, based on the historical realities of that era, it was Northern China (北中国) rather than Southern China (中国南方) that determined the destiny of China as a whole. This is because, regardless of what mutations occurred in the South and the North, up until the 7th century AD, Northern China undeniably maintained a conspicuous advantage in population and economy,

which rendered the mutations in Southern China structurally devoid of significance in the long term.

Even if the **classical bureaucratic system** (古典官僚体制) was preserved continuously in Southern China through certain mutations, had Northern China normally feudalized—regardless of whether ethnic minorities or the Han Chinese (汉族) spearheaded this process—relying on the geostrategic imbalance between Northern and Southern China alongside the North's contemporary demographic and economic advantages, I maintain it is highly improbable that the Southern Dynasties could have completed the Northern Expedition (北伐). Confronting even an initially feudalized northern regime would have been phenomenally difficult.

At the very least, what occurred in the real world was that even after four dynasties had successively replaced one another in the South, and the North-South division had exceeded two centuries, merely a single exiled Hou Jing (侯景) was sufficient to turn the lower reaches of the Yangtze River (长江下游) upside down. Furthermore, considering the technological level and the degree of Southern development during the Northern and Southern Dynasties (南北朝时期) period, if the Southern Dynasties constituted a **bureaucratic state** (官僚国家) unifying Southern China, this regime would have *de facto* found it genuinely difficult to resolve the problem of political stability, particularly during dynastic transitions. Along the entire Yangtze River stood three highly independent regional political and economic centers: Chengdu (成都), Jiangling (江陵), and Jiankang (建康). The southern regime was inevitably forced to plunge into attrition between military efficiency and political security, a dilemma practically impossible to resolve at that time.

Since a bureaucratic regime unifying the South could not annihilate the (potentially multiple) **feudal regimes** (封建政权) in the North over several centuries, once Northern China entered its high feudal period (封建盛期), what probability was there for the Southern Dynasties regime to survive an expedition by reorganized northern warriors (北方武士)? I perceive zero possibility of this.

Conversely, even if Southern China genuinely feudalized due to various reasons, as long as the historical evolution of Northern China remained identical to *Our Timeline* (本位面), then one must consider that when the **restoration-bureaucratic state** first emerged, its military power was not weak, because it ultimately retained numerous **feudal characteristics** (封建特征). The massive military deployments of the Sui Dynasty and the early Tang Empire were fundamentally sustained precisely by the North.

Yet in the 7th century, Southern China was at best in an early **feudal society** (早期封建社会). Moreover, due to realistic geographical reasons, there would exist at least four distinct regimes (*Yizhou* [益州], *Jingzhou* [荊州], *Yangzhou* [揚州], and *Jiaozhou* [交州] are highly unlikely to maintain a unified state under feudal conditions). The probability of surviving the strikes of a northern restoration-bureaucratic empire was marginal; they would roughly share the same fate as the Dali Kingdom (大理国).

Therefore, during China's Northern and Southern Dynasties, it was the North, rather than the South, that determined the destiny of China.

Although Chinese people would likely not ask such a question, foreigners unaware of the underlying context might very well say: Since Southern China (中国南方) was developed relatively

late compared to Northern China (北中国), is it possible that Southern China's **classical era** (古典时代) only commenced after the classical era of Northern China had concluded?

I maintain that this is impossible. From the Qin Dynasty (秦朝) to the Western Jin (西晋), Northern and Southern China maintained unification for over four centuries. Even calculating from the mid-reign of Emperor Wu of Han (汉武帝), the North and South were unified under China's **classical bureaucratic system** (古典官僚体制) for three centuries. Even if China's **classical bureaucratic system** was engineered with a predilection for predation from its very inception, the governance capacity of this system during the **classical period** (古典时期) was by no means poor. Classical China's **infrastructural power** (基础性权力) was absolutely among the highest of all **classical empires** (古典帝国) globally; only Rome could be compared with it.

The Hua-Xia peoples (诸夏民族) had already established their supremacy within the East Asian region on the eve of unification, and the assimilation measures propelled during the Han Dynasty—particularly during Emperor Wu's reign—were phenomenally efficacious. Therefore, while it is a factual reality that the development of Southern China lagged behind that of Northern China, it can hardly be regarded as an independent civilizational zone. This is vastly different from the relationship between Bangladesh (孟加拉国) and Northern India (北印度). Although Bangladesh largely submitted to the Indian **classical empires** under the rule of the Mauryan Empire (孔雀王朝) and the Gupta Empire (笈多王朝), compared to China, the political system of classical India was excessively decentralized; structurally, the various locales essentially remained in a state of autonomy.

Northern China and Southern China existed within a unified regime for a prolonged period. The advanced technologies of the North were rapidly transmitted to the South, to say nothing of the massive southward demographic migrations following the end of the Western Jin. Just like the barbarians (蛮族) who entered the imperial frontiers during the terminal phase of **classical empires**, the **level of productive forces** (生产力水平) in Southern China developed to a degree where the **feudal economic system** (封建经济制度) became dominant in an exceedingly brief period. Consequently, the conditions for it to independently enter a **classical period** fundamentally did not exist.

Examining the specifics, the possibility of **feudalization** (封建化) in the Southern Dynasties (南朝) basically did not exist in reality either. The reason some people might assume the Southern Dynasties could have evolved into a **feudal regime** (封建政权) is, nine times out of ten, due to a misjudgment regarding "aristocratic politics" (门阀政治).

The so-called "aristocratic politics" of the Eastern Jin (东晋) maintained a considerable distance even when compared against the threshold of **feudalization**. This is because, essentially, aristocratic politics still relied upon status within the bureaucratic system to acquire land, rather than utilizing the wealth and martial force derived from controlled land to acquire political status.

There is an ostensibly obvious problem that is particularly prone to being overlooked: the so-called Southern Dynasties were vastly different from the Eastern Roman Empire (东罗马帝国). Before the administrative division of the Roman East and West, Constantinople (君士坦丁堡) had already served as the capital for 70 years, and the imperial bureaucratic apparatus had been comprehensively reconstructed in Constantinople. The Eastern Jin, conversely, established an exiled

regime in extreme haste when the North spiraled completely out of control; it was not that easy for them to establish resistance in the South.

For several of the renowned great clans of the Eastern Jin—such as the Wang clan of Langya (琅琊王氏), the Yu clan of Yingchuan (颍川庾氏), and the Xie clan of Chenjun (陈郡谢氏)—if the colossal chaos in the Central Plains (中原大乱) directly triggered by the War of the Eight Princes (八王之乱) had not occurred, the overwhelming majority of their estates would naturally have been procured in the affluent North. Why did these southward-migrating scholar-elites (士族) re-acquire massive manors (庄园) and countless servants in Southern China by the late Eastern Jin? Because they acquired this precisely through their elevated positions within the bureaucratic system!

For example, the reason Wang Dao (王导) was able to monopolize power was that the Wang clan of Langya had already established an intimate relationship with the Sima family (司马家族) within the politics of the principality when Sima Rui's (司马睿) branch was enfeoffed as the Prince of Langya. The key reason Yu Liang (庾亮) was able to ascend so rapidly lay precisely in his usurpation of massive power utilizing his identity as an external relative of the emperor (外戚).

The power of the Eastern Jin scholar-elites was never predicated upon their control over the means of production or their dominant position over production. Instead, it was perpetually parasitic upon imperial power (皇权), and it was even less possible for them to be relatively independent of the bureaucratic system. Therefore, a phenomenally realistic problem is that within the aristocratic politics of the Eastern Jin, both the great clans and the royal Sima clan possessed a shared necessity to maintain the operation of the bureaucratic system, even though they frequently utilized their own privileges to sabotage its functioning.

Starting from the Liu Song Dynasty (刘宋), aristocratic politics was charting a continuous course toward decline. The rulers of the Liu Song Dynasty had already begun to restore the bureaucratic system's supportive function for monarchical despotism (君主专制). At this juncture, the so-called "distinction between the gentry and commoners" (士庶之别)—epitomized by the phrase "There are no poor families in the upper ranks, and no noble families in the lower ranks" (上品无寒门, 下品无士族)—essentially reflected exactly the decay of the scholar-elites' status as massive landowners. When a class's dominant position is completely unchallenged, it fundamentally has no necessity to repeatedly emphasize its own superiority and exceptionality; it only does so when its status has already begun to waver.

Starting from Emperor Xiaowu of Song, Liu Jun (宋孝武帝刘骏), monarchical power was rapidly augmented and managed to maintain a relatively elevated level throughout the entirety of the Southern Dynasties. Undoubtedly, the rulers of the Southern Dynasties indeed weaponized certain factors advantageous to a bureaucratic empire, including the tax contributions brought by the Qiao-zhi (侨置州郡 / immigrant commanderies and counties), as well as the facilitative effect of the popularization of paper on administrative management and the promotion of individuals from poor backgrounds (寒门).

In summary, expecting Southern China to play a decisive role in the *feudalization* of the entire nation during the great migrations of ethnic minorities is genuinely unrealistic.

The **second issue** involving nationalism (*although nationalism inherently did not exist at the time*) is: If China's *feudalization* (封建化) had occurred, would it inevitably have been dominated by

ethnic minorities (少数民族)? Although this question possesses not a shred of practical significance, it pertains to historical evaluation.

My answer to this is: If China's **feudalization** had proceeded normally, it is highly probable that—similar to what transpired in Europe—the dominant power would have fallen into the hands of ethnic minority rulers. However, fundamentally no one can preclude a low-probability event, namely, that under the military pressure of foreign ethnicities, Han Chinese landlords (汉族地主) rapidly transformed into **feudal lords** (封建领主) and, under the command of a formidable military leader, spearheaded the **feudalization** process. After all, we observed precisely this phenomenon in Ethiopia; although Islam projected an aggressively ferocious posture, Christian Ethiopia, retreating to the hinterlands of the plateau, nevertheless accomplished a counter-attack subsequent to its **feudalization**.

I maintain that if the ethnic minorities failed to resolutely select **feudalization** over bureaucratization, it would be fundamentally impossible for the various nomadic tribes (诸胡) to secure dominance across the entirety of China. Although the Han Chinese (汉族) population suffered precipitous reductions due to perennial warfare, during any period since the Han Dynasty, the Han Chinese unquestionably remained the most populous ethnicity within Chinese territory (*measured by modern national borders*). Therefore, the most probable landscape of a "feudal China" (封建中国) would be that the rulers of certain regimes were ethnic minorities who had "**Entered the Pass**" (入关), while the rulers of other regimes remained Han Chinese.

The ethnic minority feudal rulers would naturally promote their own cultures within their domains, and the Chinese language (汉语) might identically fracture into several relatively distinct languages. However, the reality that China remained within a single cultural sphere would not alter; these nascent Sinitic languages would broadly remain mutually intelligible. If feudal China possessed a unified church, then Classical Chinese (古典汉语) would presumably still serve as the religious language of this church.

Once China entered the **High Middle Ages** (中世纪盛期), the southern regimes might have secured an even greater advantage relative to the northern regimes. This is because historically, a crucial reason why Northern China exhibited a colossal advantage over Southern China lay precisely in the fact that a bureaucratic empire relied upon the registration of households and homogenization of the populace (编户齐民); vast, contiguous plains are undeniably conducive to this, allowing the extractive capacity of the Chinese empire to be maximally exerted. Once the entire nation underwent universal **feudalization**, the North's advantage relative to the South would diminish substantially. Furthermore, the flourishing of maritime trade would principally advantage the southern **feudal regimes** (封建政权) in their transition toward an **early modern society** (近世社会). This implies that it was highly probable the Han Chinese would re-unify the Han cultural sphere—or at least secure a dominant position—during the early modern era.

However, a far more ideal scenario naturally would be directing their gaze overseas to execute expansion; the entire periphery of China and the Nanyang (南洋 / Southeast Asia) would have become the prey of China's feudal regimes. Therefore, I contend that even analyzed from the standpoint of Han nationalism, **feudalization** remained a superior trajectory. The Han Chinese would not have been so easily defeated, and following the tempering of a **feudal society** (封建社会), they would only have emerged vastly stronger.

Moreover, I have never endorsed those grand narratives (宏大叙事) that have calloused my ears from over-repetition. In the final analysis, the interests of the Han ethnicity are constituted by the interests of trillions of ordinary Han individuals. We merely belong to the Han ethnicity in terms of identity, but what essential difference do we possess compared to individuals categorized under other ethnicities? Reflecting upon the catastrophic path the Chinese empire historically embarked upon—a path fundamentally unfathomable to ordinary human reasoning—it is genuinely difficult to assert how much value truly remains in the rigid adherence to language and religion.

The **third issue** involves the Tang-Song Transition (唐宋之变). Research concerning the mutations in Chinese society from the Tang Dynasty (唐朝) to the Song Dynasty (宋朝) has a history exceeding a century, and in terms of details, there is fundamentally nothing left to supplement. Generally speaking, the multifaceted mutations of Chinese society from the Tang to the Song were, in essence, entirely the consequence of the **ebb tide of feudalization** (封建化退潮) and the intensification of the **restoration-bureaucratic system** (复辟官僚制度).

The core lies in the fact that one of the two primary characteristics of *feudal society* most heavily emphasized by Chinese scholars (*the other being "small-scale production" [小规模生产]*)—namely, massive landownership (大土地所有制)—vanished from China to a certain degree. This is not to say that massive landlords did not exist in post-Song China; yet the factual reality remains that post-1000 AD, the degree of land concentration in China was already astronomically inferior to that of feudal Europe, exhibiting a progressively dispersive trend. China's massive estate owners, or in colloquial terms, massive landlords (大地主), could not possibly exist as **feudal lords**, nor could they exert the considerable influence in state politics that the great clans (世族) lingering during the Tang Dynasty still maintained.

By this point, the **feudal characteristics** (封建特征) possessed by the Chinese empire had essentially vanished completely. The military service system of granting land in exchange for military obligations; the land-based stipends linking the scale of granted land to bureaucratic rank; and the Fanzhen (藩镇 / regional military governors) possessing relatively independent administrative, personnel, and economic powers within their jurisdictions—all had been utterly eradicated. From the Song Dynasty through to the Qing Dynasty, the landlord class (地主阶级) never again confronted the bureaucratic imperial court (官僚朝廷) in the capacity of **feudal lords**.

The fact that the Tang-Song empires were able to orchestrate this earth-shattering grand **restoration of the bureaucratic system** indeed required exhaustive scheming. This included utilizing **co-optation through official ranks and stipends** (官位荣禄收买) to induce the great clans to disdain the control of the means of production and the production process; intentionally propelling **partible inheritance** (析产制) regarding property succession at the legal level; weaponizing the Grand Canal (大运河) to drastically augment the extractive capacity of the central government; and exploiting the imperial examination system (科举制度) to co-opt small estate owners into the hierarchical bureaucratic government. Although the outcome was catastrophic, absolutely anyone must concede that the despotic monarchs of China possessed an undeniably terrifying capability to realize this bureaucratic restoration.

However, an exceedingly fascinating historical reality is that, analyzed from the perspective of historical development, the "**Song System**" (宋制) was ostensibly far more "evil" than the "**Tang System**" (唐制). Compared to the Tang Dynasty, the paramount objective of the Song government

was pointing its bayonets inward; what the rulers worried about most was their own subjects rather than foreign barbarians. Consequently, one discovers a phenomenally bizarre phenomenon emerging in East Asia: although the **Song System** represented the further advancement of the **restoration-bureaucratic system** (复辟官僚体制), its destructiveness outside of China was actually exceedingly limited.

On the one hand, the evolution of China's **restoration-bureaucratic state** (复辟官僚国家) drastically emasculated China's capacity to interfere in peripheral regions. Even for proximate regions like Korea (朝鲜) and Vietnam (越南), I do not believe post-1000 AD China could exercise long-term control, let alone execute assimilation. On the other hand, the **Tang System** possessed a fatal attraction for the pre-feudal regimes surrounding China. China long occupied a leading position as the civilizational epicenter and vanguard of social development in East Asia; when China had already bypassed the **classical stage** (古典阶段), numerous peripheral regions still belonged to the **early state** (早期国家) stage.

The **Tang system** retained numerous **feudal characteristics** (封建因素), particularly in preserving a space for the great aristocratic clans (世家大族) within the political structure. For nations marching toward the **classical period** (古典时期) where the nobility still played a vital role in politics, this became an imitable institution. Because the **Tang system** partially retained the superiority of the feudal military apparatus while concurrently utilizing formidable bureaucratic measures to maintain regimentation and extortion over the entire society, its short-term military performance was naturally spectacular. Compared to ordinary **classical bureaucratic systems**, the **Tang system** endowed rulers with astronomically more potent **despotic power** (专制性权力); this temptation was utterly irresistible.

Therefore, the historical reality one observes is that emerging regimes on China's periphery frequently coveted the introduction of the **Tang system** on the eve of their **classical society's** (古典社会) formation. This was particularly conspicuous in Northeast Asia. The reason is exceedingly simple: Northeast Asia at that time could essentially only receive influence from China, whereas regimes in the West and South could at least recognize that China was far from being the entirety of the world.

As we pointed out slightly earlier when discussing the Goryeo Dynasty (王氏高丽), introducing the **restoration-bureaucratic system** of the Tang era during the **classical period** or slightly earlier was cataclysmic; it fundamentally severed the possibility of subsequent normal **feudalization** (封建化) in that region. Korea and Vietnam were profoundly victimized by this.

Situations only mutated in two specific locales. Because Japan (日本) introduced the **Tang system** prematurely, it "gave up halfway" (半途而废), inadvertently obliterating obstacles to **feudalization**. This stands as a rare paradigm in human history where doing nothing drastically surpassed taking action. Although Nanzhao (南诏) identically introduced the **Tang system**, the clan tribes in the mountainous terrain of Southwest China were simply too numerous and fundamentally impossible to annihilate, which furnished the conditions for Duan Siping (段思平) to harness the power of various tribes to seize Dali (大理) and establish a **feudal state** (封建国家).

Conversely, the **Song system** could not possibly become an option for peripheral regimes (*at least not until bureaucratization had reached a certain critical threshold*). This was because, *de facto*,

there was fundamentally no structural position left within the **Song system** for the nobility as an independent political force. For the rulers of Korea and Vietnam who had just expelled Chinese forces from their borders, this was a system entirely incapable of functioning. This is a phenomenally speechless state of affairs: **it was so bizarrely evil that others were fundamentally incapable of imitating it.**

It is exactly akin to the animated series *Family Guy* (《Family Guy》) produced by America's Fox Broadcasting Company. Even though every single member of the Griffin family is comparable to a beast, it is exceedingly difficult for people to believe this cartoon would generate disastrous social impacts. Because the behavior of the animated characters is so utterly depraved, the possibility of emulation fundamentally does not exist; individuals like Peter could not possibly exist in real life. Although the Song Dynasty was ostensibly vastly more friendly toward despotic monarchs, the rulers of Goryeo and Vietnam could only stare in sheer frustration.

At this juncture, people might raise another query: Since you previously asserted that Southern China and Northern China were unified under a single regime for a prolonged period and could not independently undergo the classical stage again, why do you simultaneously contend that Korea and Vietnam could? This is an exceedingly excellent question. Korea and Vietnam ultimately possessed distinctions in their relationships with China.

Chinese rule indeed once penetrated deeply into the Korean Peninsula, but that merely lasted for a little over a century during the latter half of the Western Han (西汉). Subsequently, it rapidly retracted, halting at the northwestern corner. The Eastern Han (东汉) already found the Lelang Commandery (乐浪郡) arduous to administer. Over the subsequent 400-plus years since the end of the Han Dynasty, the entire peninsula fundamentally remained heavily insulated from Chinese influence, and the subsequent presence of the Tang Dynasty was merely a fleeting flash in the pan. The first regime capable of representing the Korean Peninsula, namely Unified Silla (统一新罗国), originated in the southern part of the peninsula which had never been ruled by China; post-unification, its capital remained in present-day Gyeongju (庆州市), South Korea, at the southeastern tip of the peninsula. This signifies that the direct influence of the Chinese empire in Korea was ultimately limited; the peninsular regime could genuinely maintain a relatively independent historical evolutionary trajectory.

Vietnam was entirely different. From Emperor Wu of Han's conquest of the south until its independence from China in the mid-10th century, it was subjected to the rule of Chinese regimes for almost an entire millennium. From the precise moment Vietnam achieved independence from China, it was fundamentally impossible for it to evolve again sequentially from an **early state**, to a **classical state** (古典国家), and finally to a **feudal state**. The economic foundation of the so-called prominent great clans (世家豪强) during Vietnam's Đinh (丁朝) and Lý (李朝) dynasties was already predicated upon massive feudal manors (封建大庄园)—this irrefragably belongs to a post-classical characteristic.

Therefore, we observe that while Vietnam perpetuated the Chinese bureaucratic system, it simultaneously retained a considerable quantum of **feudal characteristics** (*alongside the village communities [村社] universally prevalent within the exceptional environments of Southeast Asia*). Yet overall, it was indeed capable of transitioning sequentially from the **Tang system** to the **Song system**, eventually even reaching a stage where it could emulate the Ming-Qing system (明清体制)

under the rule of its final imperial regime, the Nguyễn Dynasty (阮朝). Compared to Korea, Vietnam indeed resembled a "Mini-China" ("小中国") far more closely, though this is unequivocally not a complimentary description.

The **fourth issue** is exceedingly simple, primarily concerning the mutations between China's Song (宋) and Ming (明) dynasties; this is ostensibly an issue that academia observed long ago and has debated passionately.

Indeed, from a formalistic perspective, the dynastic succession from Song to Yuan (元) and subsequently to Ming over a span of roughly a century and a half seemingly subjected China to earth-shattering transformations. An era characterized by openness, ideological flourishing, technological advancement, and vibrant foreign trade (*especially private trade*) was terminated. It was replaced by the Ming Empire: extremely conservative, ideologically withered, technologically regressive, with foreign trade strictly restricted and highly shriveled. Such mutations are truly far too conspicuous for anyone to conceivably ignore. Consequently, many individuals inevitably generate rather bizarre perceptions, such as asserting that the Song Dynasty already constituted China's "**early modern society**" (近世社会). The reason I use quotation marks is because I maintain that China fundamentally never reached an **early modern society**.

Furthermore, the responsibility for China's trajectory toward failure is frequently hurled onto the heads of the Mongols (蒙古人) or Zhu Yuanzhang (朱元璋). Regarding this, my evaluation is: although I harbor zero desire to deny the colossal destruction inflicted by Mongol expansion upon various global regions, nor the crimes too numerous to record committed by Zhu Yuanzhang himself as a tyrant, the regression of the Chinese empire was absolutely not the consequence of the Yuan and Ming dynasties reversing the historical developmental trajectory. This is because the so-called prosperous landscape of the Song Dynasty fundamentally possessed zero sustainability.

First, let us examine the factors that enabled Song Dynasty China to exhibit a transient landscape of cultural flourishing. Primarily, people cannot ignore the fact that the Song rulers, in order to consolidate the **restoration-bureaucratic system** (复辟官僚体制), indeed granted massive preferential treatment and cultivation to medium and small landlords. This enabled them to secure immense profits by integrating into the bureaucratic system, facing risks vastly lower than during the Ming and Qing (清) periods. To a certain extent, this indeed successfully deceived the landlord class (地主阶级), making them believe they were genuinely "ruling the nation" and engendering enthusiasm for participating in social affairs.

Secondly, it is impossible for us not to notice that nautical technologies enabled China to intervene deeply in international trade from the southeast. Because of its massive total economic volume, China became one of the most paramount participants in global commerce; the high frequency of foreign exchange naturally identically facilitated ideological and technological progress. However, these realities never altered the fundamental essence of Song society: **it was a society under the absolute domination of the restoration-bureaucratic system**.

If we list the social identities of the renowned mathematicians and scientists from the Song, Liao (辽), Jin (金), and Yuan periods, the reality becomes blindingly clear: **they were almost exclusively officials**. Figures such as Shen Kuo (沈括), Yang Hui (杨辉), Qin Jiushao (秦九韶), Su Song (苏颂), Li Ye (李冶), Guo Shoujing (郭守敬), and Wang Xun (王恂) either entered the civil service through conventional channels or were elevated within the bureaucratic system; this roster even produced

Jinshi (进士 / highest examination graduates), Chancellors (宰相), and Grand Secretaries (大学士).

Over the 400 years of the Song and Yuan, it could be said that the sole scholar whose name was passed down as a mathematician and educator without the obligatory addition of an official identity was Zhu Shijie (朱世杰) of the Yuan Dynasty. To a certain extent, this itself was the consequence of the Mongol rulers' lack of enthusiasm for the bureaucratic system.

This single point is sufficient to definitively distinguish the Song Dynasty from a genuine **early modern society**. The relationship between the scientific and technological development of the Song-Yuan period and the bureaucratic system could no longer be encapsulated merely as "closely connected," but was arguably a relationship of tight parasitism. Outside the bureaucratic apparatus, scholars had virtually zero access to sufficient resources and information, let alone the capacity to organize and propel scientific research. Even though Zhu Shijie was a mathematician and his achievements were magnificent, in the final analysis, they could be accomplished requiring merely paper, brushes, a few books printed with predecessors' discoveries, and a brilliant mind. But could mechanical engineering and astronomical observation be achieved this way?

The factual reality is that the sponsorship of science and technology by the aristocratic stratum (贵族阶层), religious churches (宗教教会), and merchant guilds (商人行会) was virtually unobservable in Song-Yuan China; even if it existed, it was utterly negligible under the overwhelming shadow of the bureaucratic system. This bears absolutely zero relation to a genuine **early modern society**!

The so-called urbanization of the Song Dynasty was identically a grotesque urbanization engineered under bureaucratic extortion. The engine of urban development lay in the astronomical consumption of the imperial family and officials who obtained their dividends from the bureaucratic system, while the existential purpose of the colossal urban population was strictly to satisfy their insatiable luxury. The investment in culture and the arts by the Song rulers (*this inherently includes the bureaucrats*) at least generated relatively considerable impacts; after all, no one can deny that those literary and calligraphic works genuinely possess high aesthetic value. However, the investment in science and technology was egregiously microscopic relative to the total volume of social wealth expropriated. This is to say nothing of the fact that under the bureaucratic system, even if technological innovations occasionally materialized, the entire society structurally lacked the motivation to apply and refine them.

Ideologically, characterizing the Ming Dynasty as throwing it violently into reverse is undeniably correct; the problem is that the ideological mutations during the Song Dynasty inherently did not look optimistic either. The overarching ideological mutation throughout the Song Dynasty skewed toward conservatism: cardinal social ethics (纲常伦理) were reinforced, commercial activities were critiqued, and the familial status of wives and children was further degraded. The status of the Confucian Four Books (儒家四书) had already gradually ascended during the Song Dynasty; by the Yuan Dynasty, the Four Books and Five Classics (四书五经) were formally established as the primary content for examinations, explicitly mandating that examinees must interpret them strictly according to Zhu Xi's (朱熹) commentaries.

To speak frankly, I fundamentally fail to discern even a single shred of **early modern characteristics** in Song-Yuan society. Under such developmental momentum, what is there to find surprising about its subsequent evolution into Ming-Qing society?

The economic development of the Song (宋) and Yuan (元) dynasties possesses identical deceptiveness. What people frequently easily overlook is that the **bureaucratic state** (官僚国家) had already exhibited a profound impotence regarding management and participation in economic development. This is not surprising in the slightest. I have previously pointed out that one of the most paramount significances of **feudalization** (封建化) lies in the reconstruction of the social structure: the **infrastructural power** (基础性权力) of the regime, following its regression during the Early Middle Ages, ushered in a colossal restoration during the *High Middle Ages* (中世纪盛期).

Yet China fundamentally never underwent this process. The factual reality is that although the **restoration-bureaucratic system** (复辟官僚制度) ensured that the emperor's **despotic power** (专制性权力) reigned supreme globally, the *infrastructural power* of this system was vastly weaker than ordinary people imagine. After 1000 AD, Europe, having reached the *High Middle Ages*, became a primary engine of the global economy. The Islamic world (伊斯兰世界) and Southern India (南印度) simultaneously remained highly integrated into the trade network, with Muslims becoming the dominators of the maritime economic arteries. An international trade system of such complexity was entirely beyond the capacity of the **restoration-bureaucratic system** developed internally by China to handle.

In fact, the inherent objectives of the **restoration-bureaucratic system** itself were diametrically opposed to adapting to such economic mutations. One example, so glaringly obvious that it cannot be overstated, is: under the Chinese environment of the registration of households and homogenization of the populace (编户齐民), how could Chinese merchants procure reliable financial services (*especially insurance services*)? From the perspectives of technology and capital, the risk-resistance capacity of Chinese merchants in trade could not fundamentally be mentioned in the same breath as that of contemporary Muslims. It is factually correct that Chinese nautical technologies developed; yet even so, not even the most fanatical nationalist would dare assert that there were more Chinese vessels than Arab and Persian ones in the East Asian maritime zones during the Tang Dynasty (唐代). In short, the Chinese found it exceedingly difficult to seize trade dominance even right on their own doorstep.

By the Song Dynasty, industry and commerce had developed substantially, and the emergence of new technologies such as joint-stock (股份制) systems assisted the Chinese in reversing their decline in maritime trade. However, the problem lay in the fact that the increasingly complex industrial-commercial system and market were predestined to surpass the management capacity of the **restoration-bureaucratic system**. In a word, the economic level of the High and Late Middle Ages necessitated the corresponding social organization and political capacity of the High and Late Middle Ages.

From the Sui (隋) and Tang dynasties to the early Ming Dynasty (明朝初年), the **restoration-bureaucratic system** had already operated in China for nearly eight centuries. It was impossible for the imperial government to possess the capacity—especially the *infrastructural power*—to manage the socio-economic level of the 14th century. Consequently, the factual reality we observe is that, whether during the Song Dynasty or the subsequent Yuan Dynasty, some form of tax farming (包税制) universally emerged in China. Distinct from Europe's temporary employment of tax farming during its transition to the modern era to compensate for deficiencies in state capacity, China's indigenous political system fundamentally could not evolve within a few centuries to a degree sufficient to handle societal development.

Under these circumstances, the reactionary regression of the Ming Dynasty was utterly inevitable; without Zhu Yuanzhang (朱元璋), a "Ma Yuanzhang" would have emerged regardless. Only during the period when Western influence was sufficiently intense but had not yet triggered direct intervention, was the Chinese empire capable of utilizing certain factors introduced from Europe to limitedly augment its state capacity, swelling into a massive empire—namely, the Qing Dynasty (清朝)—on the eve of having its gates blown open by ironclads and artillery. As stated previously, Iran and India identically underwent this process; it is merely that they were geographically closer to Europe, thus this phase manifested earlier than in China.

In reality, anyone who meticulously observes the mutations occurring within the Chinese empire during Zhu Yuanzhang's reign will absolutely not doubt that the "supreme directive" (最高指示) of the Ming rulers for this nation was: **To strike at and isolate those factors that had become too complex and vibrant for the government to manage.** Exactly to which precise period this explicit state policy was continuously executed, I find difficult to specify accurately, but it persisted at least for over half of the Ming Dynasty, until it began to loosen in the 16th century.

The domain most profoundly impacted by this policy shift was commerce, particularly foreign trade. The Ming Empire commenced large-scale maritime prohibitions (海禁), concurrently allowing eunuchs (宦官) to occupy a phenomenally critical role in the management of China's foreign trade. This was identically inevitable. As previously mentioned, from the perspective of functional classification, eunuchs belong to highly specialized bureaucrats responsible for extracting and safeguarding the interests of the despotic monarch. Under the macro-background of the Ming Empire increasingly politicizing overseas trade (*via the tributary system [朝贡体系]*), eunuchs would inevitably inject the predatory nature of the **restoration-bureaucratic system** into international trade that inherently ought to pursue mutually beneficial outcomes. This inflicted a devastating impact on China's foreign exchanges in an increasingly globalized world. (*However, by this chronological point, it fundamentally did not matter anymore; the nation was doomed regardless, and a dead entity cannot become any more dead*).

Therefore, the so-called Song-Ming Transition (宋明之变) is merely the synthesized manifestation of two overarching tendencies characterizing the entire society and its rulers: **First, the vigorous ambition to further augment despotic power; second, the contraction generated by backward infrastructural power when confronted with governance failure.**

Consequently, two explicit characteristics inevitably emerged in terms of policy: **First, the further banditization (土匪化) of the state apparatus.** Since there were fundamentally no effective methods for long-term governance anyway, the primary consideration for both the entire bureaucratic system and the specific emperors and officials was to ruthlessly rob the populace and merchants a few times and then abscond; this mentality actually closely approximated that of nomadic regimes (游牧政权).

Second, the militarization of the open frontiers. The imperial court lacked the capacity to manage a complex society, yet feared that the merchants and fishermen active along the frontiers—especially the maritime frontiers—would metastasize into uncontrollable forces. Therefore, it was structurally compelled to adopt increasingly draconian militarized measures to enforce a *de facto* isolation of the country (锁国), utilizing martial force to suppress all social activities, even those

entirely reasonable and legitimate. Because in the eyes of the imperial court, it alone was the sole heavenly principle (天理).

Viewed from this perspective, the so-called Song-Ming Transition was fundamentally the inevitable consequence of the internal evolution of China's **restoration-bureaucratic system**; Zhu Yuanzhang merely happened to appear at that specific historical juncture. As I frequently emphasize, Zhu Yuanzhang was undeniably a tyrant steeped in heinous crimes; yet who was it that drove him to utter desperation during his youth and provided him with the stage for his perverse atrocities?

Were not the raging floods and incessant catastrophes devastating the Yellow and Huai river basins (黄淮流域) precisely the direct consequence of the **bureaucratic state** forcing the Yellow River (黄河) to flow southward continuously in order to connect the north and south via the Grand Canal (京杭大运河)? "Three diversions of the Yellow River" (三易回河)—was it not the Song Dynasty that induced artificial breaches causing the Yellow River to flow southward? Was it not the Yuan Dynasty that weaponized the southward flow of the Yellow River to construct the Grand Canal? Zhu Yuanzhang was undeniably a prime instigator of a series of monumental catastrophes for the Chinese **restoration-bureaucratic state**; however, he himself was simultaneously a victim of the countless catastrophes suffered by Chinese society.

The **fifth issue** concerns the positioning and nomenclature of historical phenomena. Regarding this issue, my friends and I have reached unprecedented consensus.

In our nation, strictly following the Bolshevik (布尔什维克) tradition, all violent resistance movements undertaken by the populace against the government in Chinese history can be termed "uprisings" (起义 / literally: righteous uprisings), regardless of whether the insurgents successfully established a new dynasty. There is fundamentally nothing wrong with this in itself; regardless of the circumstances, ordinary citizens taking up arms when driven to an absolute impasse invariably possesses an inherent, natural righteousness.

The problem lies in the fact that in China, when it is necessary to translate violent popular movements that occurred in foreign history, they are identically and indiscriminately referred to as "uprisings"—particularly regarding Europe and Japan since the Middle Ages. This is inevitably exceedingly anachronistic and profoundly deceptive. Foreign uprisings, especially popular uprisings in **feudal Europe** (封建欧洲) and Japan, were frequently a form of resistance against the government by the populace that possessed explicit political demands, and even a certain degree of organization and discipline, attempting to achieve their objectives through the display and exercise of violence.

Conversely, Chinese uprisings—particularly the uprisings during the terminal years of a dynasty—were products of the total collapse of social production; they were behavioral acts of survival sought through violent means by people entirely devoid of any alternative path to remain alive. These two distinct political phenomena fundamentally cannot be encapsulated by a single term in any conceivable sense; this is utterly absurd!

Originally, the **dynastic cycle** (王朝周期律) was a catastrophe entirely unique to China under the **restoration-bureaucratic system** (复辟官僚制度); one has fundamentally never heard of normally **feudalized** (正常封建化) regimes usually achieving dynastic transitions exclusively through uprisings. However, I personally have not yet determined what Chinese vocabulary ought to be

utilized to distinguish between the disparate popular resistance movements in Chinese and foreign history.

Actually, I believe that for the popular resistance movements in European *feudal society* (封建社会), we can entirely borrow the Japanese terminology directly—namely, referring to them as *Ikki* (一揆). This was originally a Chinese word, but in feudal Japan, it was endowed with the specific connotation of uniting to resist; employing it for Europe, which identically feudalized normally, is naturally appropriate. But how should China's drastic civil mutinies be designated? I maintain that the term "uprising" (起义) is indeed ultimately inaccurate. After all, when social production has utterly collapsed, it is truly effortless for ordinary people to degenerate into beasts desperately seeking survival regardless of the cost; exactly how many individuals still paid heed to "righteousness" (义) is genuinely questionable. The history of China is indeed so suffocatingly heavy that it is exceedingly difficult for people to locate precise vocabulary to describe it, alas!

The **sixth issue** is strictly speaking not a single question, but a series of perspectives regarding China's Ming (明) and Qing (清) eras.

Readers can presumably discern that I personally harbor a profound distaste for Ming-Qing history. This is not merely because I believe these several centuries indeed constituted historical "garbage time" (垃圾时间) for the Chinese of that era—becoming increasingly oppressive and deviating further and further from the trajectory of civilization and normal human development. It is even more because, for the people currently still living on the Chinese mainland, the Ming and Qing empires fundamentally do not count as "history." **It is not a concluded story, but merely an early iteration of what is transpiring right now.**

Consequently, for me, reading Ming-Qing history is an agonizingly torturous task. I merely need to simply exist in reality to grasp roughly what the Ming and Qing empires looked like, yet I am forced to confirm, time and time again, through that deliberately mystifying Classical Chinese (故弄玄虚的文言文) (*I call it deliberately mystifying because vernacular Chinese [白话文] in Ming-Qing China was already phenomenally mature*) exactly how many times the events of today have already transpired in the past.

However, foreign scholars find this exceedingly difficult to comprehend. I only discovered quite late that these Western Sinologists (西方汉学家) actually, and rather naively (*naturally, not everyone thinks this way, but judging from the information I acquire domestically, a considerable number indeed do*), believe that the historical divergence between China and the West formed merely within the last 500 years.

This specific matter sufficiently illustrates how the varying perspectives occupied by different individuals can generate colossal disparities in their views on the exact same issue: The Japanese embarked upon a historical trajectory diametrically distinct from China during the Tang (唐) and Song (宋) periods, hence Japanese scholars perpetually incline toward positing that a decisive mutation occurred in China from the Tang to the Song. Europeans only "discovered" China during the Ming and Qing periods, hence Western scholars are correspondingly prone to believing that China only decisively diverged from Europe during the Ming and Qing periods.

I will not overly satirize the preceding generations of foreign scholars here, because living in China myself, I can entirely comprehend the sheer magnitude of the information barriers and deliberate

deceptions they encountered while researching China. I will elaborate on the difficulties of mutual understanding between different nations in the next chapter.

What I wish to articulate here is that, although the overall macroscopic grasp of the Ming-Qing era by foreign scholars can only be described as mediocre, thanks to their naivete and outstanding academic proficiency, the history of Ming-Qing China has been researched rather lucidly from an empirical standpoint. This means that although these scholars are fundamentally unaware that they are studying an elephant, they have already developed a profound understanding of the appearances and structures of the elephant's disparate parts—such as its ears, tail, and tusks. It is merely that they are utterly clueless regarding what functions these respective parts perform on the elephant and what interconnectivity exists among them. Certain discoveries, from my perspective, remain quite valuable in assisting people to comprehend the recent evolution of the **restoration-bureaucratic state** (复辟官僚国家). I will enumerate three examples here.

The **first** reality, currently broadly acknowledged by domestic and foreign scholars and one I have mentioned repeatedly, is that land property rights in Ming (明) and Qing (清) China were exceptionally dispersed. The political and economic influence (*let alone dominant role*) of massive estate owners was fundamentally insufficient to be compared with that of genuine **feudal states** (封建国家)—whether the most advanced Britain or the relatively backward Poland. This ostensible reality powerfully refutes the persistent propaganda maintained by the government: that the evil **feudal landlord class** (封建地主阶级) constituted the greatest obstacle to early modernization. Because when confronting the **bureaucratic system** (官僚体制), they differed not in the slightest from ordinary citizens; they were identically victims. The **bureaucratic state** (官僚国家) dreaded the landlord class transforming into **feudal lords** (封建领主) and subjected them to relentless, unceasing suppression. Even if Chinese landlords desired to execute effective investments, what exactly could they do? The *de facto* reality was that they could do absolutely nothing.

The **second** fascinating phenomenon was the mutation of social mores in the Jiangnan region (江南地区) during the late Ming Dynasty, centered around Songjiang Prefecture (松江府). I have forgotten the original source of this material, though I likely encountered it in Mr. Frederic Wakeman's (魏斐德) *The Great Enterprise: The Manchu Reconstruction of Imperial Order in Seventeenth-Century China* (《洪业：清代开国史》).

Briefly stated, the prominent families in the Songjiang area during the late Ming prioritized the birth of daughters over sons. This likely exerted a certain influence on broader social mores; for instance, the aesthetic preferences of the literati (士人) increasingly feminized. This phenomenon was even observed and documented by European merchants and missionaries who had recently arrived in China. However, this fundamentally did not signify an increase in female rights or an elevation in their status. In reality, women were further degraded within this mutation, increasingly perceived as "objects" appended to patriarchal lineages.

This mutation reflected the pathological development of social concepts under the **restoration-bureaucratic society** (复辟官僚社会), where social status, power, and wealth had become inextricably bound to official rank. Even for affluent merchant and landlord families, due to genetic uncertainty and environmental instability, no clan patriarch could guarantee that the male members of his lineage would definitively achieve success in the imperial examinations (科举). Yet, provided the clan possessed a sufficient quantity of marriageable daughters, they could perpetually be utilized

as instruments of political alliance, betrothed to successful examination candidates. The reason I state there must be a *sufficient quantity* of marriageable daughters is that it was impossible to accurately predict who would become a Jinshi (进士). Therefore, families occasionally had to emulate Lü Buwei (吕不韦)—wagering on a rare commodity to hoard for profit—by identifying several potential candidates in advance and locking in marriage agreements.

Consequently, a reciprocal relationship was forged between the newly minted bureaucrat and his wife's clan: Anyone who has lived in China for any duration will not doubt that to secure promotions and amass colossal fortunes, one must be willing to expend minor fortunes to lubricate various relationships. An official just embarking on his career might lack such financial resources, rendering the support of his wife's clan absolutely critical. Once the former Jinshi had secured an elevated position within the bureaucratic system, he would weaponize his official authority and various unwritten rules (潜规则) to reciprocate his wife's lineage.

What role did the woman play in this process? She played essentially no role that manifested human characteristics whatsoever; she merely functioned as an instrument of reproduction and a token of political alliance. Such highly pathological social behavior sufficiently illustrates that by the late Ming, the **restoration-bureaucratic system** had completely annihilated all characteristics of the **feudal system** (封建体制); even the imperative of "establishing a stable patriarchal family" was actively challenged. Therefore, when the tottering Ming Empire finally remembered it ought to unleash certain **feudal characteristics** to deceive the populace into defending the imperial throne, those possessing the capacity to respond were unwilling to rescue the emperor, while those willing to assist entirely lacked the capacity. This predicament was undeniably brought entirely upon themselves.

The **third** phenomenon involves the issue of "involution" (内卷): precisely why the Ming and Qing empires appeared to possess a highly developed **commodity economy** (商品经济), yet failed to generate sufficient modern factors. I maintain that the answer to this question constitutes one of the finest achievements produced by foreign scholars in Chinese studies. Namely, the **commodity economy** of the Ming and Qing empires was largely not profit-oriented, let alone engineered for any form of capital accumulation. Rather, subsequent to the progressive monetization of Chinese taxation beginning in the late Ming, it was an act of absolute desperation undertaken by destitute peasants to cope with the myriad taxes, corvée labor, and arbitrary levies imposed by the bureaucratic government.

Rather than reflecting the affluence of the nation, the **commodity economy** of Ming-Qing China reflected its extreme destitution and the draconian severity of government extortion. During **Late Imperial China** (中华帝国晚期), commoners cultivated cash crops like gamblers. Concurrently, China, despite functioning as an astronomically massive segment of the global market at the time, could merely absorb foreign influences passively. If they won the gamble, debts could be repaid and taxes could be met; if they lost the gamble, it was the absolute end, and there was no need to consider what tomorrow might bring.

The reason I believe this phenomenon warrants attention is that, clearly, such anomalous manifestations under conditions of extreme backwardness did not emerge exclusively in China. For instance, while reading Burton Stein's (伯顿斯坦) *A History of India* (《印度文明史》), I discovered that scholars researching India had long noticed a parallel phenomenon in the Bengal (孟加拉地区)

region. Around the period when the East India Company (东印度公司) conquered Bengal, wage labor was phenomenally pervasive throughout the entire region, virtually encompassing every single household. Identical to China, the flourishing of wage labor on the eve of India's modern era fundamentally did not indicate how advanced the region was; it was solely because the Indian populace was equally overwhelmingly destitute—if they did not become wage laborers, they possessed not a singular path to survival.

I contend that such phenomena genuinely ought to command the attention of Western scholars. The social development of their own nations proceeded far too smoothly; what Europeans term major historical setbacks do not even qualify as detours here. Consequently, Western scholars are constantly prone to unthinkingly deploying certain characteristics of European modernization to execute rigid criteria application without regarding evolving circumstances (刻舟求剑) across the globe. This approach is not only detrimental to the Western world's comprehension of the non-Western world, but identically obstructs the Western world from comprehending exactly why it succeeded itself.

Apart from these six issues enumerated according to the chronological sequence of historical realities, we ought perhaps to additionally focus on the research conducted by Western scholars—particularly American scholars—regarding the economic history of ancient China. Once certain conspicuous yet profoundly crucial observations are juxtaposed against the economic history of pre-industrial Europe, China's exceptionality following the termination of its *feudalization* (封建化) wave becomes glaringly apparent.

Although numerous queries regarding ancient China's economy remain temporarily inconclusive, I remain adamantly convinced that the paradigm of the "*restoration of the bureaucratic system*" (官僚制度复辟) can consistently achieve efficacy in explaining all the unique problems China has faced since the 7th century. Here, I will cite a phenomenally renowned historical reality, one that is simultaneously the easiest for observers to notice: Prior to the Industrial Revolution (工业革命), Europe (*primarily considering Western Europe*) never behaved like China, recurrently accelerating to the maximum carrying capacity of its environmental population, only to suffer precipitous plummeting amid catastrophic cataclysms.

From the perspective of Chinese individuals, a nation like France (法国) is simply incomprehensible. I no longer know how many times I have heard people assert that France could easily sustain two or three times its current population, yet today it merely hovers around 70 million. This is not strictly a contemporary issue. Prior to the Industrial Revolution, France possessed massive surpluses in grain production, yet its demographic curve—at least relative to our nation's—remained remarkably stable.

This issue effortlessly entangles several other realities. For instance, ancient China was an exceedingly rare locale globally where pastoralism (牧业) and agriculture (农业) were highly segregated geographically. Let alone comparing it with regions like Europe characterized by a highly mixed agriculture-pastoralism system, it is said that even in India or Japan, the demarcation between agricultural and pastoral lands was never this rigidly distinct. Six years ago, when I first played the game *Kingdom Come: Deliverance* (《天国拯救》) developed by Warhorse Studios of the Czech Republic, I noticed this exact phenomenon: in medieval Europe, agricultural lands and pastoral lands exhibited a highly interlaced distribution.

However, in China, based on my observations during travels and excursions, within China Proper (长城以内的中国 / Handi), agricultural land undoubtedly occupies an overwhelming absolute majority relative to pastoral land. The Chinese precipitously converted every conceivable inch of arable land exclusively into farmland. Only on slopes where utilization was genuinely arduous would a minuscule number of herdsmen graze modest flocks of sheep, rarely exceeding a hundred head. As for cattle and horse herds, semi-wild grazing fundamentally did not exist in the interior (内地). The imperial court would attempt to breed sufficient livestock when particularly required, but the civil populace fundamentally did not operate with such considerations.

It is worth noting that this macro-spatial segregation of agricultural and pastoral lands in China was patently not the case since antiquity. During Qin-Han (秦汉) China, right in the period of the **classical empire** (古典帝国), even Handi (汉地) existed in a state of mixed agriculture and pastoralism. During the four centuries from the 3rd to the 6th century, because massive populations of ethnic minorities whose primary **mode of production** (生产方式) was originally nomadic pastoralism (游牧) entered Northern China, mixed agriculture-pastoralism was identically the norm, at least in Northern China.

The critical mutation that resulted in China's agriculture and pastoralism assuming their current segregated state occurred precisely during the Tang (唐) and Song (宋) periods. Chronologically, this perfectly coincides with the restoration of the **bureaucratic state** (官僚国家); therefore, I contend there absolutely must exist an intrinsic correlation between the two. Furthermore, we must note that pastoralism was not the only sector segregated from agriculture; forestry (林业) constitutes an identical paradigm. However, people might doubt whether the Ming (明) and Qing (清) Chinese empires even possessed any respectable forestry to begin with—because by the late Qing Dynasty, Northern China had been rendered virtually utterly barren.

My perspective is that it was precisely the colossal pressure exerted upon Chinese society by the **restoration-bureaucratic system** that coerced Chinese peasants into adopting an exclusively singular agricultural production model, rendering it fundamentally impossible for them to select a composite operational model like the Europeans.

The factual reality is that in China, let alone ordinary peasant households, even the most numerous medium and small landlords could hardly be considered genuinely "managing" (经营) land for profit; what they achieved was merely barely subsisting. Because the systemic, implicit extortion perpetrated by the **restoration-bureaucratic system** against Chinese society was truly too draconian, even if you managed it impeccably, nine times out of ten, your profits would plummet straight into the pockets of bureaucrats great and small.

Generally speaking, compared to production modes like pastoralism or forestry, agriculture yields the absolute highest output per unit of land area (*capable of sustaining the maximum population*). In order to cope maximally with myriad arbitrary levies and quotas, every individual was forcibly compelled to dedicate every single inch of land to agricultural production. Moreover, logically, pastoralism and forestry constitute medium-to-long-term asset management, making them more resilient against direct tax extraction; this directly accelerated the elimination of both sectors within a China under bureaucratic restoration.

Naturally, operating in this manner generated a cascade of consequences, which subsequently mutate into myriad "historical problems" in the eyes of contemporaries. For instance, regarding

China's unique demographic curve: Handi, adopting a highly singular agricultural production model, indeed succeeded in squeezing the carrying capacity of the land to its absolute ceiling during the pre-industrial era. However, abandoning a composite production mode inevitably signified larger-scale, more violent ecological destruction. Once an unpredictable natural disaster struck, the entire society possessed virtually zero resilience. This mode of production drastically amplified the catastrophes brought about by societal collapse during the terminal phase of every dynasty, thereby to a certain extent "accomplishing" our nation's horrifying historical demographic curve.

For another example, the fact of the chronic deterioration of horse administration (马政败坏) in China since the Tang Dynasty was identically the inevitable consequence triggered by the nationwide mutation in the production model under the oppression of the **restoration-bureaucratic system**. When China's interior practically possessed zero pastoral zones available for semi-wild grazing, from exactly where was the imperial court supposed to procure superior breeds of horses?

In stark contrast to China, within Western Europe—the most quintessential paradigm of the **feudal system** (封建制度)—politics propelled the composite operational model (复合式的经营). Western Europe was ruled by tens of thousands of **feudal lords** (封建领主) of varying magnitudes and their subordinate **knights** (骑士). For the **military aristocracy** (封建军事贵族), whether in Europe or Japan, horses were absolutely paramount. Let alone the irreplaceable role cavalry played in military operations prior to the 20th century, the horse and its associated equestrian equipment inherently constituted a symbol of feudal hierarchy.

Driven by this necessity, even if superior breeds could be procured externally, every feudal lord ultimately required the provision of a conducive living environment for horses within his own domain. Although hunting was less critical relative to horse breeding, it identically constituted an exceptionally vital social activity and ritual during the **feudal period** (封建时期), yielding considerable economic value. Therefore, under such an environment, the interlaced distribution of agricultural, pastoral, and forestry lands is not surprising in the slightest.

Yet, the feudal lord as a ruling class fundamentally did not exist within the **restoration-bureaucratic state** (复辟官僚国家); consequently, the aforementioned demands generated by political factors were even more impossible to emerge. Beyond this, the prolonged existence of the feudal system not only subjected Europeans to societal pressures astronomically lower than those in China, but simultaneously generated astonishing disparities in **social consciousness** (社会意识), customs, and jurisprudence.

Take the previously mentioned issue of inheritance law, for instance. In regions where **feudalization** (封建化) had progressed to a relatively high degree, the right to property inheritance would mutate from division toward concentration (*i.e.*, **primogeniture** [长子继承制]). *De facto*, this constrained the excessive fragmentation of land, thereby furnishing the possibility for a composite operational model; after all, if land is sliced too minutely, it genuinely becomes detrimental to executing composite operations.

Compared to the draconian circumstances in China, the overarching social environment of feudal Europe genuinely encouraged individuals to pursue commercial profits; apart from grain crops, raising sheep and cultivating grapes and olives were all highly lucrative. Therefore, in the eyes of the Chinese, Europe fundamentally never reached its requisite maximum population carrying capacity. Yet, it was precisely this gentle demographic curve that guaranteed the steady growth of

labor productivity (劳动生产率). I maintain that this is identically the profound significance of the feudal revolution for humanity: **Without a complete Middle Ages, modernization fundamentally does not exist.**

Even though I personally have clearly recognized that Karl Marx (马克思) and Friedrich Engels (恩格斯) committed numerous colossal errors, their profound realization that politics and economics are inextricably linked (*although political economy emerged even earlier*) undeniably constitutes a genuine insight. At least from my perspective, if we need to research the economic problems within Chinese history, it is fundamentally impossible to bypass the unique political system of ancient China—namely, the **restoration-bureaucratic system** (复辟官僚制度). If people researching the economic history of other regions globally could pick up the mirror of China and scrutinize it carefully, those intractable enigmas that have plagued scholars for years might very well be resolved instantaneously.

The above encapsulates the content I believe still requires supplementation regarding Chinese history. Naturally, there is a massive amount more that could be discussed, but constrained by the necessity to control the manuscript's length, I shall refrain from elaborating further. I maintain there is one immutable reality that must be etched into memory: **Since the Sui (隋) and Tang (唐) dynasties right up to the present day, every seemingly utterly incomprehensible phenomenon occurring in China is, without a single exception, the precise reflection of the restoration-bureaucratic system's influence across all societal dimensions.**

It is exceedingly ill-advised to attribute the causes to unfalsifiable "national characteristics" (民族性) or "regionality" (区域性); such explanations merely serve to camouflage the more fundamental historical realities. It is exactly like how far too many people today, observing the mutations of the Qing Dynasty (清朝) relative to the Ming Dynasty (明朝), assume it was the traits of the Manchus (满洲人) or the characteristics of the Manchu-Mongol alliance (满蒙联盟) that played the decisive role. However, the influence of these ethnic minorities merely rendered the emergence of these mutations more natural.

If a Han Chinese (汉族) dynasty had continued to rule China after the Ming Dynasty, it is highly probable it would identically have developed a parallel "Eight Banners system" (八旗制度) by observing the so-called successes and failures of the Ming Dynasty; it is merely that the characteristics of the Manchus as an ethnic minority that **"Entered the Pass"** (入关) clearly facilitated a more frictionless genesis and evolution of the Eight Banners system. This hypothetical Han regime would highly probably still have outperformed the Ming Dynasty in external military and fiscal manifestations. This is because whether considering the Ottomans (奥斯曼), Persia (波斯), or India (印度), massive empires of this precise nature invariably emerged during the historical epoch when Western influence was pronounced yet direct intervention was impossible. It was merely that the Qing Dynasty's Manchu-Mongol alliance inclined this specific regime more toward expanding into Inner Asia (亚洲内陆).

I possess a sufficiently profound understanding of China's history, have viscerally experienced China's current societal reality over these years, and have witnessed such glaring contrasts through observing the histories of other global regions. Therefore, although the preceding discourse might sound exceptionally dogmatic, I possess absolute confidence in asserting its validity. If this

manuscript can see the light of day in the future, I hope that those who read it will boldly challenge and scientifically verify these theses.

28，关于中国封建化失败之后的历史可能需要补充的一些问题的讨论

就我个人而言，我认为中华帝国隋唐之后 1400 多年的历史除了一些细节问题，在大体上已经没有什么需要讨论的。这就是一个复辟官僚国家马不停蹄地奔向绝路的历史，是中国人民所蒙受的灾难愈演愈烈的历史。然而无论如何，对自己国家的历史讨论得总是比其他国家多一些，想要查资料也要容易一些。在回到西安一年半的时间中，不少有关官僚复辟之后的中华帝国问题也在我和朋友的日常讨论中。关于这些给国内外研究者长期以来造成困惑的中国历史问题，我和朋友们一致的意见是，这些问题之所以会出现并且看起来难以解释，归根到底都是复辟官僚制度造成的，即中国本身走上了一条不归的邪路。而学者们之所以被这些问题困扰，是因为他们根本没有意识到官僚制度复辟在中国发生了，中国在理应封建化的历史时期没有封建化。人们在心理上被这个行尸走肉一样的老大帝国给唬住了，这是多么有意思的一件事！就好比丹麦童话作家安徒生所写的短篇故事《皇帝的新装》一样，隋、唐、宋、元、明、清不过是那个自以为穿了衣服但是却赤身裸体的皇帝，可是无论是这个皇帝统治的臣民，还是这个帝国以外的百姓愣是没有一个人敢直截了当地指出：这个皇帝不过是一个一丝不挂的裸男，他根本没有穿什么衣服。甚至在这位愚蠢的皇帝已经数次被他瞧不起的“蛮夷”所打垮之后，那些曾经的胜利者们竟然连想都不敢想中华帝国不过是如此货色。这样的事情实在是令人啧啧称奇，自从人类有史以来，没有人听说这样的笑话。

第一个讨论得比较多的问题是，在晋朝末年中国统一古典国家解体之后，流寓江左的南朝政权是否可能正常封建化。读者想必已经看到，我在一开始考虑中国的封建化问题时采取的就是重北轻南的观点，没有对江左六朝进行多少讨论。我之所以使用这种处理方式是因为在我看来，从当时的历史事实中看，北中国而不是中国南方决定了整个中国的命运。因为无论南方和北方发生怎么样的变化，一直到公元七世纪为止，北中国在人口和经济上一定是占有显著优势的，这就使得中国南方的变化在长远来看缺少意义。

就算古典官僚体制在中国南方经过一些变化一直保存了下来，但是如果北中国正常封建化了，无论主导这个进程的是少数民族还是汉族。就凭借南北中国之间地缘战略上的不平衡性以及当时北方的人口和经济上的优势，我认为南朝不太可能完成北伐，面对的是初步封建化的北方政权也难。至少现实世界发生的情况是即使在南方已经相继更迭了四个朝代，南北分裂已经超过两个世纪，仅仅是一个流亡的侯景就足以把长江下游搅得天翻地覆。况且以南南北朝时期的技术水平和南方开发程度而论，南朝如果是一个统一中国南方的官僚国家的话，这个政权在事实上确实难以解决政治上的稳定性问题，特别是在统治者换代的时候。在整个长江沿岸分立着成都，江陵和建康三个独立性很高的区域政治和经济中心，南方政权不得不在军事效率和政治安全中陷入消耗中，这在当时几乎不可能解决。既然统一南方的官僚政权在几个世纪内消灭不了北方的（可能不止一个）封建政权，那么一旦北中国进入封建盛期，南朝政权能有多少概率再重新组织起来的北方武士的讨伐一下幸存？似乎看不到这种可能性。

反过来说，就算中国南方因为种种原因真的封建化了，但是只要北中国的历史演变和本位面没有区别。那么人们就必须考虑复辟官僚国家在刚刚出现的时候军事力量并不衰弱，因为它毕竟保留了很多封建特征。隋朝和唐帝国前期的大规模用兵，支撑其军事力量的基本上也就是北方。而在七世纪，中国南方充其量处于一种早期封建社会，而且出于现实的地理原因少说也会有四个政权存在（益州，荆州，扬州，交州在封建状态下不太可能维持一个国家），能够在北方复辟官僚帝国的打击下生存的概率不大，大致会和大理国一个命运。因此在中国的南北朝决定中国命运的是北方而非南方。

虽然中国人大概不会问这种问题，但是不明就里的老外很可能会说：既然中国南方相对北中国开发得比较晚，那么有没有可能在北中国的古典时代结束之后中国南方的古典时代才开始呢？我认为这没有可能，从秦朝到西晋，南北中国维持了超过四个世纪的统一。即使从汉武帝执政中期开始算，在中国的古典官僚体制下南北统一也有三个世纪。就算中国的古典官僚体制在设计之初就偏向于掠夺，但是在古典时期这套体制的治理能力并不差，古典中国的基础性权力在全世界所有古典帝国中绝对是数一数二的，只有罗马能与之相比。诸夏民族在统一前夕就已经在东亚地区确立了自己的优势，汉代尤其是武帝时期推进的同化措施又卓有成效。因此中国南方开发晚于北中国是事实，但是难以被视为一个独立的文明区域。这与孟加拉国之于北印度的关系是很不一样的，孟加拉国虽然在孔雀王朝和笈多王朝的统治下大致也臣服于印度古典帝国。然而和中国相比古典印度的政治体制过于分散了，各地方本质还是一种自治的状态。北中国与中国南方长期在一个统一政权中，北方的先进技术很快就传播到了南方，更不用说西晋末年之后大规模的人口南迁了。就如同古典帝国结束时期进入帝国边疆的蛮族一样，中国南方的生产力水平在很短的时间内就发展到了封建经济制度占优势的程度，因此就没有独立再进入一个古典时期的条件。

具体来看，南朝事实也基本不存在封建化的可能性。之所以有人可能会认为南朝可能像封建政权演变，十有八九是因为对于“门阀政治”存在误判。东晋的所谓“门阀政治”即使跟封建化的门槛来比也是有相当距离的，因为门阀政治本质上仍然是凭借官僚体制中的地位来获取土地，而不是由所控制的土地的财富和武力来取得政治地位。有一个显而易见的问题尤其容易被忽视，那就是所谓的南朝跟东罗马帝国很不一样。在罗马东西分治之前，君士坦丁堡就已经做了 70 年的首都，帝国的官僚机构已经完整地在君士坦丁堡重建了。而东晋则是在北方完全失控的情况下仓促之间建立起了流寓政权，它想在南方建立抵抗没有那么容易。对于东晋有名的几个大族来说，例如琅琊王氏、颍川庾氏、陈郡谢氏，如果没有八王之乱直接引发的中原大乱，他们的产业绝大多数当然会置办在富庶的北方。为什么到了东晋后期这些南渡的士族在中国南方重新拥有了庞大的庄园和不计其数的仆从？因为他们正是通过在官僚体制中的高位获得了这一点。就好比王导之所以能够掌权，是因为琅琊王氏在司马睿一支封为琅琊王的时候就已经在封国政治中与司马家族建立了亲密的关系。庾亮之所以能够迅速崛起，关键在于他以外戚的身份攫取了大量权力。东晋士族的权力从来都不是基于其对于生产资料的控制和生产的支配地位上，而是始终依附于皇权，更不可能相对独立于官僚体制了。因此一个非常现实的问题就是，在东晋的门阀政治中，门阀和皇族司马氏具有共同的维护官僚制度运作的需求，虽然说他们常常会用这种自己的特权破坏制度运行。从刘宋开始，门阀政治就在一路走向没落，南朝宋的统治者已经开始恢复官僚体制对于君主专制的支持作用。这个时候所谓“上品无寒门，下品无士族”的“士庶之别”，在本质上恰恰反映了士族作为大地主者地位的衰落。在一个阶级的统治地位完全不受挑战的时候，它根本没必要反复强调自己的优越性和特殊性，只有在地位已经开始动摇的时候才会这么做。从宋孝武帝刘骏开始，君主权力迅速得到加强，并且在整个南朝都能够维持比较高的水平。毫无疑问南朝统治者确实利用了一些对于官僚帝国有利的因素，包括侨置州郡带来的税赋贡献，以及纸张普及对于行政管理和提拔寒门的促进作用。总而言之，指望南中国在少数民族大迁徙中对全国的封建化起到决定性作用确实不现实。

第二个涉及民族主义的问题（虽然本身也不存在）是中国的封建化如果发生了，是不是必然由少数民族主导？这个问题虽然说不具备半点现实意义，但是这涉及历史评价问题。对此我的回答是，如果中国的封建化正常进行，大概率会像欧洲所发生的事情一样，主导权落入少数民族统治者手中。可是又没有任何人能够排除这样一种小概率事件，即汉族地主在异族的军事压力下迅速向封建领主转化，并且在一个强大的军事领袖统帅下主导了封建化进程。我们毕竟在埃塞俄比亚就发现了这样的现象，虽然伊斯兰教表现得气势汹汹，但是向高原腹地撤退的基督教埃塞俄比亚仍然在封建化之后完成了反击。我认为如果少数民族没有能够在封建化和官僚化中坚定选择前者，诸胡也基本没有可能在中国全境都取得统治地位，汉族人口虽然因为常年战乱锐减，但是在汉朝以来的任何一个时期汉族都毫无疑问是中国境内（以现代

国境为标准)人口最多的民族。因此“封建中国”大概率的形势是一些政权的统治者是入关的少数民族,另一些政权的统治者仍然是汉族。少数民族封建统治者当然会将自己的文化在领地内推广,汉语也可能分裂为几种差别比较大的语言。不过中国处于一个文化圈内的事实不会改变,这些新的汉语族语言之间大致上也能够沟通。如果封建中国有一个统一的教会的话,那么古典汉语应当仍然是这个教会的宗教语言。

等到中国进入中世纪盛期,南方政权相对于北方政权可能变得优势更大。这是因为历史上北中国相对于中国南方之所以显示出了巨大的优势,一个重要的原因在于官僚帝国是编户齐民的,而连片的大平原的确有利于编户齐民,中华帝国的压榨能力得以充分发挥。一旦全国都普遍封建化了,北方相对于南方的优势就会减弱很多。况且海上贸易的兴盛也首先有利于南方的封建政权向近世社会转变,这意味着汉族很有可能在近代早期重新统一汉文化圈或者至少取得优势地位。不过更理想的情况当然是把目光投向海外进行扩张,整个中国周边地区以及南洋都会是中国封建政权的猎物。因此我认为即使站在汉民族主义的立场上看,封建化依然是一条更好的道路,汉族没有那么容易被轻易地打倒,在封建社会的锤炼之后只能变得更强。更何况我从来也不认同已经听到耳朵磨出茧子的宏大叙事,汉民族利益归根到底是亿万个普通汉族人的利益所构成的,我们只不过在认同上属于汉族,但是和其他被归为其他民族的人又有什么本质区别呢?想一想中华帝国在历史上走上的,常人完全难以猜度的灾难性道路,语言和宗教的坚守真的很难说还有多大价值。

第三个问题涉及唐宋之变,关于从唐朝到宋朝中国的变化在研究已经有超过一个世纪的历史,在细节方面基本上也没什么能补充的。总体来说,从唐到宋的中国社会方方面面的变化在本质上都是封建化退潮和复辟官僚制度增强的结果。核心在于中国学者最为强调的封建社会的两个主要特征之一(另一个为“小规模生产”),即大土地所有制在某种程度上从中国消失了。这不是说宋代以后的中国不存在大地主,但事实的确是自公元一千年以后,中国的土地集中程度已经远远不如封建欧洲,而且呈现出愈发分散的趋势。中国的大地产者或者按照通俗的说法,大地主,不要说能够作为封建领主存在,就是像唐代时期仍然遗留的世族一样能够在国家政治中起到可观的作用都不可能了。至此中华帝国所具有的封建特征基本上完全消失,通过赐予土地换取军事服役的兵役制度,将赐田规模与官僚等级相挂钩的田产俸禄,在辖区内有相对独立行政、人事和经济权力的藩镇,已经被完全消灭了。从宋代到清代,地主阶级再也没有作为封建领主与官僚朝廷相抗衡。唐宋帝国之所以能够实现官僚体制的惊天大复辟的确也是费尽心机,包括用官位荣禄来诱导世族使其轻视对生产资料和生产控制,有意从法律层面推动财产继承的析产制,借助大运河增强中央政府的汲取能力,利用科举制度拉拢小地产者进入科层制政府等等。虽然结果是灾难性的,但是任何人都不得不承认中国的专制君主能够实现官僚复辟确实也是他们的一种本事。

然而一个非常有趣的事实是,如果我们从历史发展的角度来说显然“宋制”比“唐制”要更为“邪恶”。与唐朝相比,宋朝政府最大的目的就在于把刺刀对向内部,统治者首先担心的是自己的子民而非外夷。因此人们会发现亚洲东部出现了一种非常怪异的现象,尽管宋制是复辟官僚体制的进一步发展,但是它在中国之外的危害性却非常有限。一方面是中国复辟官僚国家的演变大大削弱了中国对于周边地区的干涉能力,即使对于朝鲜和越南这样邻近的地区,我也不认为公元一千年后的中国能够长期地进行控制,更不要说展开同化了。另一方面是唐制对于中国周边的前封建政权来说具有吸引力,这一点尤为致命。中国作为亚洲东部的文明中心和社会发展长期处于领先地位,当中国已经越过古典阶段的时候,周边很多地区还属于早期国家阶段。而唐朝体制中保留了不少的封建因素,尤其是为世家大族在政治结构中留有一席之地,这对于正在迈向古典时期的,贵族仍然在政治中扮演重要角色的国家而言成为一种能够模仿的制度。唐朝体制既部分保留了封建军事体制的优越性,又通过强有力的官僚手段维持对全社会的管

制和压榨，其短期内的军事表现自然亮眼。而比起一般的古典官僚制度来说，唐制赋予统治者更加强大的专制性权力，这种诱惑全然难以抵挡。

因此人们看到的历史事实是，中国周边地区的新兴政权往往渴望在古典社会形成前夕引入唐制。这一点在东北亚体现得尤为明显，原因很简单，东北亚在当时基本上只能受到来自中国的影响，而西方和南方的政权至少能认识到中国远非世界的全部。就如同我们在稍早的地方讨论王氏高丽的时候已经指出的，在古典时期或者稍早的时间点引入唐代的复辟官僚制度是灾难性的，这基本上断绝了该地区接下来正常封建化的可能，朝鲜和越南就深受其害。只有在两个地方形势发生了变化：日本因为引入唐制过早“半途而废”，反而为封建化扫除了障碍，这是人类历史上少有的无为远胜有为的例子。南诏虽然也引入唐制但是中国西南山地中的氏族部落实在过多又不可能消灭，为段思平借助各个部落的力量入主大理建立封建国家提供了条件。而宋制就不可能成为周边政权的选择（至少在官僚化达到一定程度前不会），因为宋代体制中已经事实上没有作为独立政治力量的贵族的位置了，这对于刚刚把中国势力驱逐出境的朝鲜和越南统治者来说是一个根本运转不了的体制。这是一种让人十分无语的状态：因为坏得太过离奇以至于别人无法模仿。就如同美国福克斯（Fox）公司出品的动画片《Family Guy》一样，明明 Griffin 一家个个堪比畜生，但是人们却很难认为这个动画片会产生糟糕的社会影响。因为动画角色的行为实在是太坏了，以至于根本没有被模仿的可能，生活中不可能有 Peter 这样的人。宋朝虽然对于专制君主而言显然更为友好，但是高丽和越南的统治者也只能望其兴叹了。

这里人们或许还会提出一个疑问，既然之前已经说过中国南方与北中国长期统一在一个政权下，不会再独立地经过古典阶段，为什么又认为朝鲜和越南可以呢？这个问题问得非常好，朝鲜和越南两国在与中国的关系上毕竟有所区别。中国的统治的确曾经大幅深入到朝鲜半岛，但那不过是西汉后半段一个世纪出头的时间，随即就回缩到了止在西北一角。东汉对于乐浪郡本来就已经难于管理，汉末以来 400 多年间整个半岛事实上又很难受到中国影响，随后唐朝的存在也只是昙花一现。第一个能够代表朝鲜半岛的政权即统一新罗国，它发源于朝鲜半岛从未被中国统治的南部，统一之后的首都仍然在半岛东南端的现今韩国庆州市。这就意味着中华帝国在朝鲜的直接影响毕竟是有限的，半岛政权的确能够保持相对独立的历史演化进程。越南就不一样，从汉武帝征服南方到十世纪中叶从中国独立，1000 年间几乎都在受中国政权统治。越南从中国独立伊始它就不可能再从早期国家到古典国家到封建国家再演化一遍了，越南丁朝和李朝的所谓世家豪强的经济基础已经建立在封建大庄园上了，这无论如何都属于后古典的特征。因此我们看到越南在沿袭中国官僚制度的同时保留了相当多封建因素（还有东南亚特殊环境下普遍存在的村社），但是总体来说的确能够按照唐制到宋制，至最后一个帝制政权阮朝统治时甚至已经可以模仿明清体制这样的过程转变。越南与朝鲜相比的确更像“小中国”，不过这显然不是什么褒义的形容。

第四个问题非常简单，主要涉及中国宋明两朝之间的变化，这显然是学术界早就观察到并且讨论热烈的问题。的确，从形式上看宋一元一明三朝更迭在大约一个半世纪的时间里似乎是中国发生了翻天覆地的变化，一个开放的，思想繁荣的，技术先进的，对外贸易（尤其是民间）兴盛的时代结束了。取而代之的是一个极端保守，思想凋零的，技术退步的，对外贸易受到严格限制并且高度萎缩的明帝国。这样的变化实在是太过显而易见，以至于任何人都不能忽视。因此很多人必然会产生一些奇奇怪怪的认识，比如说宋代已经是中国的“近世社会”，我之所以打引号，是因为我认为中国从来没有到达过近世社会。而中国走向失败的责任，往往被扔到蒙古人或者是朱元璋的头上。对此我的评价是，虽然我一点都不想否认蒙古扩张对于世界各地造成的巨大破坏以及朱元璋本身作为一个暴君犯下的罄竹难书的罪行，但是中华帝国的倒退绝不是元、明两朝扭转历史发展进程的结果，因为宋代的所谓繁荣局面根本就不存在可持续性。

我们首先来看造成宋代中国能够出现文化繁盛一时的局面的因素有哪些？首先人们没办法忽视的是宋朝统治者为了巩固复辟官僚体制，的确对于中小地主给予了极大优待和扶植，使他们能够通过加入官僚体制获得极大的收益，而风险则远小于明清时期。这确实可以在某种程度上欺骗地主阶级，让他们以为自己真的在“统治国家”，并且产生出参与社会事务的热情。其次我们不可能注意不到的是，航海技术使得中国从东南方深度介入到国际贸易当中，并且因为中国自身经济总量的庞大成为世界贸易最重要的参与者之一，对外交流的频繁当然也有利于思想和技术的进步。但是这些事实从来没有改变宋代社会的本质，这是一个复辟官僚制度统治下的社会。

如果我们把宋、辽、金、元时期有名的数学家和科学家的社会身份列出来事情就很明了了，他们几乎都是官员。沈括、杨辉、秦九韶、苏颂、李冶、郭守敬、王恂等人不是走常规的途径入仕，就是在官僚体制内受到提携，这里面甚至还出了进士、宰相和大学士。在宋元 400 年间可以说唯一一个可以不加上官员身份，以数学家和教育家之名流传后世的学者是元朝人朱世杰，甚至这某种程度上来讲都是蒙古统治者对于官僚制度缺少热情的结果。单此一条宋朝跟真正的近世社会就足以区别开来，宋元时期的科学技术发展与官僚体制之间已经不是“联系密切”能够概括得了，而是一种可以说紧密的依附关系。在官僚体制之外，学者几乎接触不到足够的资源和信息，更没有能力组织和推动科学研究。哪怕朱世杰也是个数学家，他取得的成就虽然伟大，但是归根到底只需要纸、笔、几本印刷着前人成果的书籍以及一个聪明的大脑就能完成，可是机械制造和天文观测可以吗？事实就是贵族阶层，宗教教会以及商人行会对于科学技术的赞助在宋元中国你几乎就看不到，就算有在官僚体制的影响下也是可以忽略的，这跟一个真正的近世社会简直没有半点关系。

宋代的所谓城市化同样是官僚剥削下一种畸形的城市化，城市发展的动力在于获得官僚体制分肥的皇室和官员一掷千金的消费，而庞大的城市人口存在的意义就是满足他们的穷奢极欲。宋代统治者（这里包括官僚）对于文化艺术的投资至少还产生了比较可观的影响，毕竟没人能否认那些文学和书法作品的确颇具观赏价值。然而对科学技术的投资相对于社会财富被剥削的总量相比就太微不足道，更不要说在官僚体制下即使偶有技术创新，整个社会也缺乏对其进行应用和改良的动力。就思想上来看，说明代大开倒车确实是没错，问题是宋代思想发展的变化看起来本来也不乐观。有宋一代的思想变化在整体上是偏向于保守的，纲常伦理受到强化，商业活动受到批判，妻子和子女的家庭地位被进一步贬低。儒家四书的地位在宋代就已经逐渐上升，元朝的时候正式确立了四书五经为考试的主要内容，并且规定考生必须按照朱熹的注释进行解读。这我说实话，就完全看不出来宋元社会有哪怕一丝一毫的近世特征，在这种发展趋势下向明清社会演进有什么可奇怪的。

宋元经济的发展同样具有欺骗性，人们往往容易忽略的是官僚国家对于经济发展已经展现出了一种在管理和参与上的无力。这一点毫不奇怪，我在之前就已经指出封建化的一个最主要意义在于社会结构进行重组，政权的基础性权力经过中世纪早期的衰退之后在中世纪盛期迎来了大幅度的恢复。而中国根本就没有经历这个过程，事实就是复辟官僚制度虽然确保了皇帝的专制性权力在全世界独领风骚，但是这个体制的基础性权力远远没有常人想的那么强。在公元 1000 年之后，已经到达中世纪盛期的欧洲成为世界经济的一个主要引擎，伊斯兰世界和南印度又始终高度接入贸易网络，穆斯林成为海洋经济动脉的主导者。复杂到这种程度的国际贸易体系就已经完全不是中国自身发展出的复辟官僚体制能够应对的。事实上，复辟官僚制度本身的目的就与适应这种经济变化相悖，一个最显而易见到不能再显而易见的例子就是，在中国编户齐民的环境下，中国商人怎么获得可靠的金融服务（尤其是保险服务）？从技术和资本上来说，中国人在贸易的抗风险能力上根本不可能与当年的穆斯林同日而语。中国航海技术要说发展是没错的，但是即使如此，连最狂热的民族主义者都不敢说唐代的东亚海域里中国人的船只多于阿拉伯人和波斯人的。简而言之，中国人连自己家门口的贸易主导权都难以抢到。

到宋代的时候工商业有了很大发展，股份制这样的新技术出现有助于帮助中国人在海上贸易中扭转颓势。可是问题在于，日益复杂的工商业体系和市场注定要超出复辟官僚制度的管理能力以外。一言以蔽之，中世纪盛期乃至晚期的经济水平需要与之配套的中世纪盛期和晚期的社会组织 and 政治能力。从隋唐到明朝初年，复辟官僚制度在中国已经运行了将近八个世纪，帝国政府不可能拥有应对 14 世纪社会经济水平的能力，尤其是基础性权力。因此我们能够看到的事实是，无论是在宋代还是在之后的元代，某种形式的包税制在中国普遍出现了。而与欧洲在向近代过渡时期暂时性地使用包税制以弥补国家能力的不足不同，中国自己的政治体制根本就不可能在几个世纪内发展到足以应付社会发展的程度。在这种情况下，明朝的反动是必然的，没有朱元璋也会有马元璋。只有在西方影响足够强烈又不至于引起直接干涉的时期，中华帝国能够利用一些从欧洲传入的因素来有限度地增强其国家能力，在被坚船利炮打开国门前夜膨胀为一个大帝，即清朝。如前所述，伊朗和印度也经历了这个过程，只不过他们离欧洲更近，所以这个阶段出现得要比中国早一些。

事实上，任何人只要仔细观察朱元璋统治时期中华帝国发生的变化，就完全不会怀疑明朝统治者对于这个国家的“最高指示”就是：对于已经复杂和活跃到政府难以进行管制的因素进行打击和隔离。这种明确的国家政策具体延续到哪个时期我也很难说得准，不过至少持续了明朝超过一半的时间到 16 世纪才开始松动。受到政策转变影响最大的领域就是商业领域，尤其是对外贸易。明帝国开始进行大范围的海禁，同时让宦官在中国的对外贸易管理中占据了十分重要的角色。这也是必然的，之前已经说过宦官从职能分类上来说就属于高度分化的，为专制君主攫取和维护利益的官僚。在明帝国将海外贸易日益政治化（通过朝贡体系）的大背景下，宦官必然会把复辟官僚体制的掠夺性引入原本应该追求共赢的国际贸易中，这对中国在一个日渐全球化的世界中对外交流造成了毁灭性的影响。（不过到这个时间点已经无所谓了，反正这个国家已经完蛋了，死人总不能变得更死）因此所谓宋明之变无非是整个社会及统治者两种倾向的综合表现：第一是进一步加强专制性权力的勃勃野心，第二是落后的基础性权力在面临治理失能时产生的退缩。于是在政策上必然会产生两个特点：第一是国家机构进一步土匪化，反正也没有能够长期治理的有效办法，无论是整个官僚体制还是具体的皇帝和官员首先考虑的事情都是对于百姓和商人狠狠抢劫几次然后走人，这种心态其实跟游牧政权非常接近。第二是开放边疆的军事化，朝廷没有能力对于复杂社会进行管理，又担心这些活跃在边疆，特别是海洋边疆的商人和渔民成为难以控制的力量，就必然采取越来越严格的军事化措施进行事实上的锁国，通过武力打压哪怕是合情合理的一切社会活动，因为在朝廷看来它自己就是唯一的天理。如此看来，所谓宋明之变根本就是中国复辟官僚体制自身演变的必然结果，朱元璋只不过是恰好出现在那个历史位置罢了。就如同我经常强调的一点，朱元璋确实是一个恶贯满盈的暴君，但是是谁在他年少的时候把他逼入绝境，又给了他倒行逆施的舞台？黄淮流域肆虐的洪水和无休止的灾难，不正是官僚国家为了京杭大运河贯通南北而迫使黄河一直南流的结果吗？

“三易回河”，人为决口导致黄河难流的难道不是宋朝吗，利用黄河南流修建京杭大运河的难道不是元朝吗？朱元璋固然是中国复辟官僚国家一系列重大灾难的推动者，然而他本人也是中国社会所遭受的无数次灾难的受害者。

第五个问题涉及的是历史现象的定位和命名，关于这个问题，我和我的朋友们达成了空前的一致。在我国依照布尔什维克的传统，中国历史上的一切民众对政府采取的暴力反抗运动都可以称为“起义”，无论起义者是否建立起了新的王朝。这本身没什么问题，无论如何普通百姓在走投无路的关头举兵起事总是有天然的正义性。问题是在中国当需要翻译外国历史上发生的民众暴力运动时也会不加区分地称之为“起义”，尤其是对中世纪以来的欧洲和日本也如此处理，这必然是非常不合时宜并且有欺骗性的。外国的起义尤其是封建欧洲和日本的民众起义往往是一种带有明确政治诉求的，甚至有一定组织和纪律性的，通过展示和行使暴力以求达成目标的民众对于政府的反抗。而中国的起义尤其是王朝末年的起义属于社会生产全面崩溃的产物，是人民在没有任何活路的情况下通过暴力手段谋求生存的行为。这两种政

治现象在各种意义上根本不可能用一个词语进行概括，这太荒谬了！原本王朝周期律就是中国在复辟官僚制度下特有的灾难，根本就没听说过正常封建化的政权能够总是通过起义的方式实现改朝换代。不过我个人还没有想好应该用什么汉语词汇对于中外历史上不同的民众反抗进行区别。其实我认为对于欧洲封建社会的民众反抗运动完全可以直接把日本的说法借来用，也就是直接称为“一揆”，这本来也是一个汉语词只不过在封建日本被赋予了团结起来反抗的含义，用在同样正常封建化的欧洲自然也是合适的。不过中国的激烈民变应该怎么称呼呢？我认为起义这个词确实还是不准确，毕竟在社会生产已经完全崩溃的情况下老百姓真的很容易沦为不顾一切寻找活路的野兽，究竟还有几个人注意到“义”的确是个问题。中国的历史的确太沉重，以至于人们很难找到确切的词语对其进行形容，哎！

第六个问题严格来讲并非一个问题，而是有关中国明清时代的一系列看法。读者想必也能看出来，我个人很不喜欢明清史，这不仅仅是我认为这几个世纪对于当年的中国人来说的确是日益深重，距离文明和人类正常发展道路越来越遥远的垃圾时间。更是因为明清帝国对于现在仍然生活在中国大陆的人们而言根本算不上什么“历史”，它就不是已经结束的故事，而是现在正在发生的事情的早期版本。因此对于我来说阅读明清史是一个非常折磨的工作，我明明在现实生活中只需要简单活着就知道明清帝国大致是什么样子，还不得不从那些故弄玄虚的文言文中（之所以说故弄玄虚，是因为明清中国的白话文已经相当成熟了）一次又一次确认今日之事在曾经已经发生了多少遍。

然而外国学者难以理解这些，我在很晚的时候才发现这些西方的汉学家们竟然天真地（当然不可能所有人都这么想，只是说从我在国内获得的信息来看，的确有不少人这么认为）认为中国与西方的历史差异是在最近 500 年内形成的。从这件事情上足以看出不同人所在的视角会使得他们对于同一个问题的看法造成多大的区别：日本人在唐宋时期走上了跟中国截然不同的历史进程，所以日本学者总是会倾向于从唐朝到宋朝中国发生了决定性变化；欧洲人一直到明清时期才“发现”中国，所以西方学者也容易倾向于认为在明清时期中国才决定性地与欧洲相分别。我在这里也不多吐槽前辈的外国学者们，因为我本人在中国完全能够理解他们在研究中国时遇到了怎么样的信息壁垒和有意欺骗。关于不同国家互相了解的困难我会在下一章进行论述。这里我想说的是，虽然说外国学者对于明清时代的整体把握可以说一般。但是多亏了他们的天真以及出色的学术水平，明清中国的历史从史实上说已经被研究得比较清楚。这就是说，虽然这些学者们根本没有意识到自己在研究一头大象，但是他们对于大象的不同部分，例如耳朵，尾巴和象牙的样子和结构已经非常了解，无非是不清楚这些部分分别在象身上扮演什么样的功能，具有什么样的联系罢了。一些发现在我看来对于帮助人们理解复辟官僚国家在最近的演化还是比较有价值的，我在此列举三例。

第一个现在已经被国内外学者广泛承认的，我也已经提到多次的事实是，明清中国的土地产权相当分散，大地主者在政治和经济上的影响力（甚至不必提支配作用）根本不足以同真正的封建国家相比，无论是最先进的英国还是相对落后的波兰。这个显而易见的事实能够有力反驳官方一以贯之的宣传，那就是邪恶的封建地主阶级是近现代化最大的阻碍，因为在面对官僚体制的时候他们和普通百姓并没有什么区别，都是受害者罢了。官僚国家恐惧地主阶级向封建领主转化，每时每刻地进行打压，中国的地主即使想要进行有效投资又能做什么呢？他们事实上就是什么也做不了。

第二个有趣的现象是明末江南地区社会风气的变化，以松江府为中心。这段资料我已经忘记了原始出处，不过应当是在魏斐德先生（Frederic Wakeman）的《洪业：清代开国史》中看到的。简单来说就是当时的明晚期松江地区的大家族不重生男重生女，这可能对于社会风气都产生了一定的影响，例如士人的审美取向也变得女性化。这种现象甚至已经被当时刚刚来到中国不久的欧洲商人和传教士观察并记录。然而这完全不意味着女性权利增长和地位提高，实际上女性在这个变化中被更加贬低，越来越被视为附属于父系家族的“物品”。这种变化反映了复辟官僚社会下由于社会地位、权力和财富已经彻底与官位相

绑定，社会观念的病态发展。即使对于富裕的商人和地主家庭来说，因为遗传的不确定性和环境的不稳定性，任何宗族族长都不能保证本家的男性成员一定可以在科举中取得成功。但是只要本家族中有数量足够的待嫁女子，那么她们总是可以作为联姻的工具被许配给科举中的成功者。之所以说必须有数量足够的待嫁女子，原因是人们不可能精确地预测谁能做进士，所以有的时候就非得学吕不韦赌一把奇货可居，提前物色几个有潜力的对象然后定下婚事。这样一来新晋官僚就和妻族之间建立了一种互惠关系：任何只要在中国生活过一段时间的人都不会怀疑想要升官发大财，就必须舍得小财以打点各种关系，刚步入仕途的官员未必有这种财力，妻族的支持就非常关键。等到曾经的进士已经在官僚体制中身居高位，他就会利用职务之便以及各种潜规则回馈妻子的家族。女人在这个过程中扮演了什么角色呢？基本没有扮演任何能够体现出人类特征的角色，只是作为生育工具和政治联盟的信物。这种高度病态的社会行为充分反映了到明末为止复辟官僚制度已经完全摧毁了封建体制的一切特征，连“建立稳定的父系家庭”这一点都受到了挑战。因此当明帝国摇摇欲坠时统治者终于想起来应该释放一些封建因素来欺骗大家保卫自己的皇位，有能力响应的人都不愿意勤王保驾，有意愿勤王的人又根本没有能力，这种局面实在是咎由自取。

第三个现象涉及“内卷”问题，也就是为什么明清时期中华帝国看起来已经存在高度发达的商品经济，但是却没有产生足够的近现代因素。我认为这个问题的回答是外国学者在中国研究中做出的最好的几个成果之一。即明清帝国的商品经济很大程度上不是以盈利为目的，更谈不上进行任何形式的资本积累。而是从明后期开始中国税收逐渐货币化之后，赤贫百姓为了能够应对官僚政府的各种税役和摊派而进行的孤注一掷的行为。明清中国的商品经济非但反映的不是这个国家的富裕，而是这个国家极端的贫困以及政府剥削的严重。在中华帝国晚期，老百姓像赌徒一样种植经济作物，而中国虽然作为当时世界市场极为庞大的一部分却只能被动地接受外来影响。如果赌赢了那么债务有得还，税也有得交；如果赌输了更是一了百了，明天怎么样都不需要考虑了。我之所以认为这个现象值得注意，原因在于，显然不只是在中國一个地方出现了这种在极端落后情况下的反常表征。例如我在读伯顿斯坦的《印度文明史》时发现研究印度的学者早都注意到了孟加拉地区也存在着相似的现象。在东印度公司征服孟加拉国前后，整个地区的雇佣劳动极为普遍，甚至几乎覆盖到了每一个家庭。与中国相同的是，近代前夜印度雇佣劳动的繁荣根本无法说明这个地方有多发达，只是因为印度百姓一样太过穷困了，但凡不成为雇工就没有一点活路。我认为类似的现象的确应该为西方学者所注意，他们自己国家的社会发展实在太过顺利，欧洲人所谓的重大挫折在我们这里连弯路都算不上。因此西方学者总是容易不假思索地拿着欧洲近代化的一些特征到全世界各个地方干刻舟求剑般的事，这种做法既不利于西方世界了解非西方世界，同样会阻碍西方世界认识自己为什么能够成功。

除了这六个依照历史事实的时间顺序所列出的问题以外，我们或许还应当关注西方学者特别是美国学者对于中国古代经济史的研究。一些虽然明显，却至关重要的观察一旦与前工业时期的欧洲的经济史进行对比，中国在封建化浪潮结束之后的特殊性就会清楚地显露出来。虽然中国古代经济的诸多疑问暂时难有定论，但是我依然坚信“官僚制度复辟”在解释中国自七世纪以来一切独有问题上能够起到一贯的成效的。在这里我举一个非常有名的，同时也是观察者们最容易注意到的一个历史事实，那就是在工业革命发生之前，欧洲（主要考虑西欧）从来没有像中国一样屡次迅速抵达环境人口承载上限，然后又在大灾变中锐减。在中国人看来，像法国这样的国家简直就是不可理喻，我已经不知道听过多少人说过，法国完全可以承载两三倍的人口，但是现在也不过只有 7000 万人。这不只是现在的问题，在工业革命之前法国的粮食生产就大大有余，但是其人口曲线至少相对于我们国家来说实在太平稳了。

这个问题又很容易牵扯出其他一些事实，比方说，古代中国是世界上极为罕见的牧业和农业在地理区域上高度分离的地方。不要说和欧洲这种农业和畜牧业高度混合的地区相比，即使是在印度或者日本，据

说农业和牧业用地也没有如此泾渭分明。六年前我第一次玩捷克战马公司制作的游戏天国拯救

（《Kingdom Come: Deliverance》）的时候就注意到了这一点，在中世纪欧洲，农业用地和牧业用地呈现出交错的状态。但是在中国，根据我在旅行和郊游途中的观察，对于长城以内的中国，农业用地的确相对于牧业是压倒多数。中国人早早就把凡是能用来种植的土地全部开辟为农田，只有在实在难以利用的坡地，会有极少数牧人赶着数量不大的羊放牧，几乎不会超过百头。至于牛群和马群，在内地几乎不存在半野生式的放牧，朝廷在特别需要的时候会试图饲养足够的牲畜，但是民间不会这么考虑。值得注意的是，中国的农业和牧业用地在大空间上分离的局面显然不是自古皆然，在秦汉中国，正处于古典帝国的时期，即使是汉地也处于一种农牧混合的状态。在 3 到 6 世纪 400 年间，因为大量原本以游牧为主要生产方式的少数民族进入北中国，农牧混合至少在北中国也是常态。中国的农业和牧业之所以呈现出现在这种状态，关键的变化发生在唐宋时期，这与官僚国家复辟在时间上是一致的，因此我认为其中必然存在内在联系。而且我们也要注意与农业分离的并非只有牧业，林业也是一样的例子，不过人们或许会怀疑到明清时期中华帝国到底还有没有像样的林业，因为在清末的北中国，这里几乎是光秃秃的一片了。

我的观点是，恰恰是复辟官僚制度对于中国社会所施加的重压，迫使中国农民采取了极为单一的农业生产模式，而不可能像欧洲人一样选择一种复合式的经营方式。事实就是，在中国，不要说是普通的农户，即使是数量最多的中小地主都很难称得上真的在“经营”土地以营利，他们所做的无非是勉强维持现状。因为复辟官僚制度对于中国社会的隐性剥削实在是太过严重，就算你经营得当，你的盈利十有八九也会落到大小官僚手里。一般而言，农业相比于牧业或者林业这样的生产方式单位土地面积出产是最高的

（能够养活的人口是最多的），为了尽可能应对各种摊派，每个人都不得不把每一寸土地都用于农业生产。更何况，牧业和林业在逻辑上处于一种中长期的资产经营，且较难受到税务管理，这就加速了两者在官僚复辟的中国被淘汰。这样做当然会带来一系列的后果，进而在今天人看来变成好多个“历史问题”。比如说中国特有的人口曲线，长城以内的汉地采取高度单一的农业生产方式，的确做到了在前工业时期把土地承载力压榨到上限。但是放弃了符合生产方式就必然意味着更大规模的，更猛烈的生态破坏，一旦出现难以预测的天灾，整个社会是极其缺乏抵抗能力的。这种生产模式在每一个王朝后期会大大加剧社会崩溃所带来的灾难，因此便一定程度上“成就”了我国骇人听闻的历史人口曲线。又比如说中国自唐朝以来马政败坏的事实，它同样是复辟官僚制度压迫下全国性生产模式转变带来的必然后果，当中国内地已经几乎没有供半野生放牧的牧区时，朝廷又从哪里获得良种马匹呢？

与中国相反，在封建制度最为典型的西欧，政治推动了复合式的经营。西部欧洲由大小不一，数以万计的封建领主及其麾下的骑士所统治，对于封建军事贵族来说，无论在欧洲还是日本，马匹都是至关重要的。不要说在 20 世纪之前骑兵在军事活动中扮演了无可替代的位置，马以及与马有关的装备本身就是一种封建等级的象征。出于这种原因，哪怕良马可以来自外界，每一个封建领主总归是需要在自己领地内为马匹提供良好的生活环境。狩猎相对于养马来说虽然没有那么要紧，但是同样在封建时期是一种非常重要的社交活动和仪式，并且提供可观的经济价值。因此在这种环境下，农业、牧业和林业用地交错就毫不奇怪。而封建领主作为统治阶级在复辟官僚国家根本不存在，以上由于政治因素产生的需求就更不可能出现了。除此之外，封建制度的长期存在不仅使欧洲人处于远比中国小得多的社会压力下，同时社会意识、习惯和法律也产生了惊人的差异。就好比之前已经提到过几次的继承法问题，在封建化已经进行到较高级的地区，财产继承权会由分割向集中变化。这在事实上就遏制了土地的过度分割，为复式的经营模式提供了可能，毕竟如果土地被切分的太过细碎确实也不利于进行复式经营。封建欧洲整体的社会环境相对于中国那种恶劣的情形确实是在鼓舞人们追求商业利益，除了粮食作物以外，饲养绵羊，种植葡萄和橄榄都有利可图。因此在中国人看来，欧洲根本就从来没有达到它应有的人口承载力上限，

但是就是这样平缓的人口曲线确保了劳动生产率的稳步增长。我认为，这同样是封建革命对于人类的重要意义，没有一个完整的中世纪，就不存在近代化。

即使我本人已经清楚地认识到马克思和恩格斯犯过不少重大的错误，但是他们把政治和经济紧密相连的认识（虽然政治经济学更早就出现了）确实是真知灼见。至少在我看来，如果我们需要研究中国历史上的经济问题，就不可能绕开中国古代特有的政治体制，也就是复辟官僚制度。如果人们在研究世界其他地方的经济史问题时能够拿起中国这面镜子仔细端详，那些曾经困扰人们多年的疑难说不定将会顷刻之间迎刃而解。

以上就是我认为有关中国历史仍然需要补充的内容，能说的当然还有很多，但是限于控制篇幅的原因就不再多说了。我认为有一个事实需要牢记，那就是自隋唐至今所有在中国发生的，看起来完全难以理喻的现象，无一例外地都是复辟官僚制度在社会各个方面影响的反映。把原因归为那些难以证伪的“民族性”和“区域性”非常不明智，这些解释只能掩盖更为基本的历史事实。就好比现在太多人看到清朝相对于明朝的变化就认为是满洲人的特质或者满蒙联盟的特征起到了作用，但是这些少数民族影响不过是使得变化的出现更为自然罢了。如果明朝之后统治中国的仍是一个汉族王朝，那么它一样很可能通过观察明朝的所谓得失发展出一套“八旗制度”，只不过显然满洲人作为入关少数民族的特质使得八旗制度出现和流变更为顺畅。这个汉族政权在对外军事表现和财政表现上极大概率还是要比明朝好，因为无论是奥斯曼，波斯还是印度都在西方影响显著但是又没办法直接干涉的历史时期出现了这样的大帝国，只不过清代满蒙联盟使得这个政权更倾向于向亚洲内陆扩张而已。我对中国的历史有足够的了解，在这些年里深刻感受到了中国的社会现状，又通过对世界其他地方历史的观察看到了如此鲜明的对比，因此以上言论虽然听起来极其武断，但我有充足的信心认为它是对的。如果这份记录将来能够问世的话，希望读到的人能够大胆质疑并科学求证这些论点。